Al-Ḍarūrī الضروري في أصول الفقه

Ibn Rushd · Gnamma Research · Printable A4

Complete authorial §§1–258. No scholarly apparatus, notes, dictionary, cases or exercises. Full commentary remains in the scholarly reference edition.

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Introduction

[1] To proceed, after praising God, who teaches articulate expression, makes inquiry (النظر) and inference (الاستدلال) obligatory, and singles out the human being for establishing conclusive arguments and setting forth examples; and after invoking blessings upon Muḥammad, the seal of the messengers and the culmination of completeness and perfection: my purpose in this book is to set down for myself, as a reminder, a sufficient account of what is necessary (ضَرُورِيّ) in this craft (الصناعة), drawn from Abū Ḥāmid's book on the principles of jurisprudence (أُصُول الْفِقْهِ) entitled al-Mustaṣfā—may God have mercy upon him. In doing so we shall seek the briefest and most concise expression, and what seems to us most technically appropriate to this disciplined art. Before this, let us offer a useful introduction (مُقَدِّمَة) concerning the purpose and benefit of the knowledge (عِلْم) sought here. We say:

[2] Forms of knowledge and the sciences are of three kinds. There is knowledge whose end is simply the assent it produces in the soul: for example, knowledge that the world has come into being, the doctrine of the indivisible part, and similar matters. There is knowledge whose end is action. Some of this is universal (كلية), and its benefit for action is indirect, while another part is particular (جزئية) and its benefit for action is more direct. Particular knowledge includes knowledge (عِلْم) of the rulings governing prayer and almsgiving, and similar particular obligatory and recommended observances. Universal knowledge includes knowledge of the principles on which these branches (فُرُوع) are built—the Book, the Sunna (سُنَّة), and consensus (إِجْمَاع)—and knowledge of the rulings derived from these principles in general, their divisions, and what attaches to them insofar as they are rulings (أحكام).

There is also knowledge that provides the rules and conditions through which the mind is guided towards correctness in these two forms of knowledge: for example, knowledge (عِلْم) of indications (الدلائل) and their divisions, of the conditions under which they are indications and those under which they are not, and of the cases in which the passage from the observed to the unobserved is employed and those in which it is not. Let us call this a method of examination (سِبَار) (sibār) and a standard (قانون) (qānūn). Its relation to the mind is like that of the compass and straightedge to sense perception (حِسّ) in matters where error cannot be ruled out.

[3] It is clear that the more ramified the sciences become, and the more those investigating (نَظَر) them must resort, in order to apprehend them, to matters to which their predecessors did not have to resort, the greater their need for rules that protect their minds during inquiry.

It is also clear that the craft called jurisprudence (الفقه), both at present and in the past since the death of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—the dispersal of his Companions through the lands, and the divergence of what was transmitted (نَقْل) from him—God bless him and grant him peace—exhibits these two conditions. For this reason the Companions—may God be pleased with them—had no need of this craft (صِنَاعَة), just as the Bedouin Arabs had no need of rules to protect them in their speech or their metres.

[4] What we have said makes the purpose of this craft intelligible and disposes of the objection that the people of the earliest generation did not investigate it. We do not, however, deny that they employed its capacity: you can discern this from their legal opinions—may God be pleased with them. Indeed, many of the universal notions (الكلية المعاني) laid down in this craft (صِنَاعَة) were

validated precisely through induction (الاستقراء) from their legal opinions, case by case.

[5] The parts of this craft (صِنَاعَة), according to its division in this book, are four. The first part comprises inquiry into rulings (الأحكام); the second, into the sources (أَصْل) of rulings; the third, into the proofs (الأدلة) employed to derive each ruling from its respective source, and how they are employed. The fourth comprises inquiry (نَظَر) into the qualifications of the practitioner of independent judgement (المجتهد), who is the jurist.

[6] From our preceding account of the purpose of this craft and the genus of sciences to which it belongs, you know that its proper inquiry lies only in the third part of this book. The other parts belong to the kind (جِنْس) of knowledge (عِلْم) whose end is action. Hence they named this craft after some of what they made a part of it, calling it 'the principles of jurisprudence (أُصُول الْفِقْهِ)' (الفقه أصول). Inquiry (نَظَر) conducted according to the requirements of the craft (صِنَاعَة) demands that this third part receive a separate treatment, since it differs in genus from those other parts, and that, concerning those, one of two courses alone be adopted. Either they should be posited according to the most widely accepted doctrines concerning them—for example, the views of the People of the Sunna (سُنَّة).

Or the disagreements concerning them should be outlined and enumerated, and the conditions and rules provided through which rulings are derived according to each opinion about those principles. This would explain, generally, how some of those opinions follow from others and how they correspond to the branches (فُرُوع): one would explain, for example, how derivation proceeds according to the Ẓāhirīs (أهل الظاهر, commonly called Literalists) and according to those who affirm analogy (القياس)—in general, according to each of the widely accepted opinions. This course is more useful in this craft. Through such inquiry (نَظَر) this kind (جِنْس) of knowledge would possess a craft (صِنَاعَة) that is complete, universal (كُلِّيّ), and sufficient for the inquiry of all who practise independent judgement (حُكْم) (الاجتهاد).

[7] We have nevertheless decided to follow the customary practice of the practitioners of kalām (mutakallimūn) in this discipline (صِنَاعَة) and, in dividing it, to seek the arrangement found in this book, since it is the best considered and the most likely to conform to the requirements of the craft. We shall, however, indicate something of that purpose.

[8] Our preceding account makes clear this book's purpose, its relation to the other sciences, its rank, what its name signifies, and its divisions. These are the general matters that it is useful to present to the learner when beginning the craft (صِنَاعَة). Let us begin where he began.

[9] Before this, Abū Ḥāmid placed a logical introduction (مُقَدِّمَة). He stated that he was led to discuss it by the inquiry of those treating this craft (صِنَاعَة) into certain logical matters, such as their inquiry (نَظَر) into the definition (حَدّ) of knowledge (عِلْم) and other things. For our part, let us leave each thing to its proper place. Anyone who attempts to learn more than one thing at a time will be unable to learn even one of them.

Part I · Legal rulings

Discussion of the First Part of This Book

[10] This first part is divided into four parts: inquiry (نَظَر) into the definition (حَدّ) of a ruling (الحكم), its divisions, its constituent elements, and what manifests it.

First Section

[11] According to the People of the Sunna (سُنَّة), a ruling (الحكم) is defined as the address of the Law (الشرع خطاب) when it concerns the acts of legally responsible persons by requiring an act (فِعْل) or its omission. Where this address has not occurred, no characterization as good (حُسْن) or bad attaches to acts; on this account, goodness and badness are not intrinsic attributes of acts.

The Muʿtazilites held that goodness (حُسْن) and badness are intrinsic attributes of acts. Some are apprehended through rational necessity (ضَرُورَة), as with lying and thanking a benefactor; others, with the Law (شَرْع)'s assistance, as with ritual purification and prayer, because of, for example, wording (لَفْظ) said to restrain indecency and the cleanliness involved [the printed wording of this example is uncertain]. The benefit of knowing this disagreement within this craft (صِنَاعَة) becomes apparent when investigating (نَظَر) analogy from a suitable, plausible ground (القياس المناسب والمخيل),

with all its kinds, and when investigating whether those exercising independent judgement are correct or mistaken.

The argument of the People of the Sunna (سُنَّة) is that 'good (حُسْن)' and 'bad' have several meanings in the usage (عُرْف) of speakers. The first and most familiar is what accords with or opposes the purpose of the person judging it good: one person, for instance, may find a dark complexion good and another find it bad. This is a relational matter, unlike the blackness and whiteness belonging to things in themselves. The second is what the Law (شَرْع) has declared good or bad. The third meaning (مَعْنَى) of 'good' is what a person is permitted to do. All these are relational, not intrinsic, attributes. This means that goodness and badness have no existence as intrinsic properties of things in external reality.

[12] The Muʿtazilites, for their part, argued that goodness (حُسْن) and badness are intrinsic attributes of things from the agreement of rational persons in affirming them without qualification by a relation—for example, the goodness of truthfulness and the badness of lying; in general, from these propositions' being widely accepted and agreed upon. It is evident that intelligible matters may also happen to be widely accepted, but that the converse does not hold.

[13] Discussion of this question does not belong to the science (عِلْم) with which we are engaged. Neither of these two arguments seems sufficient to settle it. The Muʿtazilites argued that obligation in certain matters—thanking a benefactor and the like—is apprehended by reason (عَقْل). Restricting its apprehension to the Law (شَرْع) would leave the messengers unable to answer when they call people to inquiry (النظر). Unless we know that inquiry is obligatory, we shall not inquire; unless we inquire, we shall not establish the Lawgiver's claim concerning that to which he calls us; and unless we establish his claim, there is no way to believe what he calls us to. Whether what we are called to is true in itself or not, on this account there is no way for us to attain knowledge of it.

[14] The theologians pressed a difficulty upon the Muʿtazilites concerning their claim that the obligation to inquire is apprehended rationally. If this obligation is rationally apprehended, that must be either necessarily or through acquisition. If necessarily, no one would be heedless of the knowledge (عِلْم) of God. If acquired by inquiry (نَظَر), the question turns back upon them: how is the obligation to undertake the inquiry leading to the obligation to inquire into the Law (شَرْع)'s claim apprehended? And so on without end.

[15] What should be said here, in my judgement, is that assent (التصديق) to the Lawgiver's claim when a miracle appears in accordance with it belongs to the kind (جِنْس) of necessary knowledge. Assent arises necessarily from witnessing this, or through the miracle's being established by recurrent transmission (تواتر). The question whether inquiry is obligatory or not arises only where knowledge is gained through inquiry and inference (النظر والاستدلال). Straining after any further account here merely confuses beliefs or causes needless trouble. If each person called to the Law (شَرْع) were to take upon himself such difficulties when considering what the Law calls him to, the faith of many people would never arise, or would arise only rarely.

In general, God's calling people to faith in the Law (شَرْع) by such paths would, for most people, amount to imposing what is beyond their capacity. That knowledge (عِلْم) of this is necessary (ضَرُورِيّ) does not entail that no one can fail to acknowledge it. Just as being necessary is not a condition of what is agreed upon, so being agreed upon is not a condition (شَرْط) of what is necessary. None of this belongs to the present science.

[16] Those Muʿtazilites who held that acts are permissible before the advent of the Law intended by this only acts concerning which reason (عَقْل) judges neither goodness nor badness. Those among them who spoke of suspension of judgement seem to me to have had in view acts whose goodness (حُسْن) or badness is apprehended only when the Law is joined to reason, as previously stated among their opinions. As for those who say that acts are prohibited before the advent of the Law (شَرْع), this assertion has no meaning (مَعْنَى) and is manifestly untenable in itself.

Discussion of the Second Section of the First Part

[17] This section comprises inquiry (نَظَر) into the divisions of rulings (الأحكام), their definitions, and questions attaching to them. We say: the ruling whose description was given above is divided into a demand to act, a demand to omit, or a choice

between the two; the last is called permissible (مباح). The demand to act is divided into obligation (وَاجِب) and recommendation (نَدْب); omission, into prohibition and disapproval.

The obligatory (الواجب) is defined as that whose performance the address (خِطَاب) of the Law (شَرْع) prefers, with a threat of punishment for omitting it insofar as this constitutes its unqualified omission. We added ‘with a threat of punishment for omitting it’ because, according to the People of the Sunna (سُنَّة), obligation cannot be conceived apart from harm or benefit. We further added ‘insofar as this constitutes its unqualified omission’ as a precaution concerning an obligation that permits a choice.

The threat of punishment may be established with certainty or by probable judgement (ظنا). Abū Ḥanīfa's followers reserve the name farḍ (فَرْض) for the first and wājib (وَاجِب) for the second. There is no dispute over names once their meanings are understood.

The recommended (الندب) is defined as that whose performance is preferred without a threat of punishment for its omission. From the definition (حَدّ) of the obligatory (وَاجِب) we apprehend that of the prohibited, its opposite; likewise, from that of the recommended we apprehend that of the disapproved (مَكْرُوه). The permissible is that concerning which the Law (شَرْع) indicates equality between performance and omission. This occurs either through an address (خِطَاب) allowing a choice between them, through removal of blame from both, or through a rational indication (دَلِيل) that original freedom from liability (البراءة الأصلية) remains because there is no legal proof attaching a ruling (حُكْم) to it, as will be explained later.

Chapter

[18] The obligatory is divided into what is determinate and what allows a choice among a limited set of alternatives, either concerning the act (فِعْل) or concerning the time. They call an obligation whose act is not fixed, but admits a limited set of alternatives, an obligation allowing a choice (المخير الواجب); one whose time is not fixed, an obligation with an extended time (الواجب الموسع).

[19] The Muʿtazilites denied both the rational possibility of such an obligation and its occurrence in the Law. They said: if the three alternatives in expiation are equal in their character with respect to the servant's welfare (صَلَاح), all ought to be made obligatory (وَاجِب) because they are equally conducive to it. This is based on their doctrine of welfare and the best possible welfare.

Yet, even if this principle were granted, the contrary of what they posit would follow: if each alternative equals the others in bringing about welfare (صَلَاح), employing all of them is pointless, as is selecting one particular alternative; and they do not allow such purposelessness in God. They appear not to have guarded their own principles in this question. They also argued that God's knowledge (عِلْم) concerns the alternative the servant will perform, which is therefore necessarily determinate in itself; no choice is conceivable in such a case.

[20] Discussion of this question does not belong to the science (عِلْم) with which we are engaged. Here it is enough to say that such a thing does occur in the Law, as with the alternatives in expiation and the established consensus (إِجْمَاع) that most prayers have extended performance periods. The Muʿtazilites are bound to encounter the same difficulty they raised here in the case of the permissible. In general, this objection attaches to the possible insofar as it is possible.

[21] Some jurists rejected calling such a thing obligatory. They said that, with respect to time, it is characterized by obligation (فَرْض) only at the end of the period, since punishment attaches to failing to perform the prayer then. At the beginning of the period, however, they call it recommended, since omitting the prayer at that point incurs no penalty. A similar objection applies to an obligation offering a choice: no individual alternative can be considered obligatory, as the final moment of the prayer period can, unless the other two alternatives become unavailable; only then does the obligation of the third become conceivable. What should be said of such a case is that it resembles obligation in one respect and recommendation (نَدْب) in another. Its resemblance to obligation (وَاجِب) lies in the discharge of the duty by praying at the beginning of the period; its resemblance to recommendation is that mentioned in the objection.

[22] This dispute is verbal; hence it was called an obligation (وَاجِب) with an extended time. It also

differs from recommendation (نَدْب) in that its omission is allowed only on condition (شَرْط) of resolving to perform it while mindful of it, since resolving to omit it altogether is forbidden.

Chapter

[23] They likewise disagreed whether that without which an obligation cannot be fulfilled should itself be called obligatory. The proper account is that this is divided into what the servant has no choice in producing—for example, the capacity to walk—which is not characterized as obligatory but is a condition (شَرْط) of imposing an obligation; and what the servant can produce by choice, which should be characterized as obligatory, such as the ritual purity required for prayer. The obligation of such a thing seems to be for the sake of something else, not for its own sake. Another division of the obligatory (وَاجِب) therefore emerges: some things are obligatory for the sake of something else, and some are obligatory in themselves.

The obligatory is also divided into what is measured by a determinate amount and what is not, such as wiping the head and maintaining stillness in bowing. For obligations of the latter class, the required (وَاجِب) amount is the least to which the name of the act (فِعْل) applies; anything beyond that is recommended. This distinction is conceivable only for acts performed successively or in sequence—in general, for acts whose parts do not occur simultaneously.

[24] Such is the account of the definition and division of the kinds of rulings (الأحكام). There remains the discussion of universal (كُلِّيّ) questions attaching to them.

[25] The first question is this. If the legally responsible person (مُكَلَّف) dies during the allotted period without having discharged the duty, he does not die disobedient: the early generations agreed on this. Whoever declares him sinful is mistaken, for we know with certainty that they did not declare sinful someone who died after enough time had elapsed to perform the prayer.

If it is asked how omission with a resolve to act can be allowed when he does not know whether the outcome will be safe, we answer: such omission is allowed only until a time he judges it more probable than not that he will survive to, just as one administering discretionary punishment may strike up to a point at which death is not the predominant probability. Hence Abū Ḥanīfa—may God have mercy upon him—said that pilgrimage may not be postponed for a year, since survival until then is not predominantly probable; fasting and almsgiving, however, may be postponed for one or two months. Al-Shāfiʿī—may God have mercy upon him—regards survival for a year as predominantly probable (ظَنّ) for young people.

Second Question

[26] Rulings are divided, as previously explained, into the obligatory and, at the opposite extreme, the prohibited (حَرَام), which is the forbidden. Between them lie two intermediates: the recommended (نَدْب) and the disapproved (مَكْرُوه). It is clear that where opposites admit an intermediate, removing one does not entail the existence of the other. Whoever claimed that when obligation is abrogated (نَسْخ) a thing returns to its previous prohibition was therefore mistaken. That would follow only if there were no intermediate between the obligatory (وَاجِب) and the forbidden. Clearer still is its reversion to its previous permissibility (إِبَاحَة), since permissibility is not included under the genus (جِنْس) to which these opposed rulings belong, namely demand (الطلب).

[27] Here the untenability of the claim that the permissible is commanded becomes clear. It is likewise clear that it does not belong to the imposition of legal responsibility (التكليف), since this is the demand for something involving a burden. Whoever calls it an imposition of responsibility, meaning that we are obliged to believe it permissible in the Law or obliged to believe that it belongs to the Law (شَرْع), strains the terminology. In general, this is a linguistic inquiry (نَظَر) more suited to another place. The preceding account also makes clear that the recommended (مَنْدُوب) is commanded, since it involves a certain demand and requisition. As for the claim that ‘command’ applies only where omission incurs punishment, that is a linguistic claim; its proponent must establish it through either legal usage or linguistic convention.

Third Question: The Forbidden Is the Contrary of the Obligatory

[28] If contraries are defined as two things that cannot coexist in one numerically identical thing, at one time and in one respect, then prohibition and obligation cannot in the Law (شَرْع) attach to

one thing in one respect at one time. Their attachment to two things or at two times is, however, undisputed; prohibiting one does not invalidate the other, whether the distinction concerns two things or two times. The same must hold when prohibition (نَهْي) and obligation attach to one thing in two respects—for example, when something is commanded without qualification, and then that very thing is prohibited as qualified by an attribute or on account of an expressly stated cause (عِلَّة).

In cases of this kind (جِنْس), however, they disagreed whether the prohibition invalidates the originally obligatory act insofar as it is qualified. Abū Ḥāmid—may God have mercy upon him—stated that they divide this into what concerns something other than the prohibited act, owing to an external cause (سَبَب), and what concerns an attribute of the thing itself. What concerns something other than the prohibited act does not invalidate the original (أَصْل) act. Concerning what relates to an attribute of the prohibited act, al-Shāfiʿī held that it invalidates the original act; where he gave effect to divorce during menstruation, he referred the prohibition (نَهْي) to the infliction of harm and included it in the first division.

Abū Ḥanīfa does not consider the prohibition (نَهْي) to invalidate the original (أَصْل) act in either case, whether the prohibited act is qualified by an attribute or by an external cause (سَبَب). He held that ritual impurity's invalidation of prayer was established only by the proof (دَلِيل) of consensus (إِجْمَاع).

[29] I consider that inquiry (نَظَر) into this question concerns only the verbal form (لَفْظ) of prohibition. For one who understands the form (صِيغَة) of prohibition to signify that an act is forbidden, a prohibition (نَهْي) applying to that act under a particular qualification, after its unconditional obligation has been established, is a contextual indicator (qarīna (قَرِينَة)) that turns the apparent prohibition from strict forbiddance into disapproval (كَرَاهَة). This is more clearly so if a prohibition attaches to the act on account of some external matter after the act has been enjoined without qualification. We shall discuss this later.

If, however, the question is considered from the standpoint of meaning (مَعْنَى), prohibiting a thing as qualified by some matter—whether a cause or an attribute—after making it obligatory without qualification invalidates the original (أَصْل) act insofar as it is qualified (مُقَيَّد). Precisely what you have understood here concerning a qualified prohibition (نَهْي) issued after an unqualified obligation should be understood concerning a qualified obligation issued after an unqualified prohibition.

[30] It is surprising that Abū Ḥāmid treated inquiry (نَظَر) into this question as belonging to this part of this book.

[31] Whoever permits prayer in a valley, a bathhouse, or camels' resting places should interpret the prohibition concerning these as disapproval (كَرَاهَة) rather than forbiddance, following the doctrine that prohibiting something as qualified by an external matter, after permitting or commanding it without qualification, supplies a contextual indicator shifting the expression (لَفْظ) of prohibition (نَهْي) from forbiddance to disapproval. This applies if he holds that the form (صِيغَة) of prohibition entails forbiddance. For someone who does not hold this, the matter is easy.

Whoever invalidates prayer on usurped land because it consists of prohibited movements and spatial positions does so through ignorance of the definitions of contraries: obligation and prohibition (حَرَام) attach to it in two different respects. That is why the Companions—may God be pleased with them—agreed not to command wrongdoers to repeat their prayers upon repentance. These movements and spatial positions are commanded in one respect and prohibited in another. Similarly, prostration before an idol without intending [worship of it] is forbidden in one respect and an act of drawing near [to God] in another.

Fourth Question

[32] People have disagreed whether making something obligatory prohibits its contrary, and whether prohibiting it makes its contrary obligatory. We say:

[33] As for when the two contraries are defined according to their proper definition (حَدّ) and the term is not used loosely, making a thing obligatory prohibits its contrary. For, as previously explained,

whatever is indispensable to fulfilling an obligation is obligatory (وَاجِب), whether it is an act (فِعْل) or an omission. This question is conceivable only in legal contrariety (التضاد الشرعي). As for perceptible contrariety, abandoning the contrary is indispensable for the imposition of responsibility to be possible: it belongs to the conditions of the act.

[34] As for the prohibited, if it has no contrary, or has a contrary (ضِدّ) but admits an intermediate between them, prohibiting it does not entail making anything obligatory. If, however, the thing cannot be without one of the two and there is no intermediate between them, prohibiting it makes its contrary obligatory. This too applies where the contrariety is legal; if it is perceptible, it belongs to the conditions of legal responsibility (تَكْلِيف).

[35] This is how the question and its answer should be interpreted. Here the discussion of the second section of this part ends.

Discussion of the Third Section of the First Part

[36] This section comprises inquiry (نَظَر) into the constituent elements of a ruling (الحكم). They are three: the one who rules, the person subject (مَحْكُومٍ عَلَيْهِ) to the ruling, and that concerning which the ruling is made.

[37] The one who rules is the speaker whose address imposes obligation. In addition to being a speaker, he must possess unrestricted authority for the ruling (حُكْم) to take effect. This holds only between owner and owned, creator and created; the ruler is God Most High. Everyone whose obedience is obligatory—the ruler, the father, and the like—is owed obedience only because God Most High has made it obligatory. He has the power to punish and reward, since obligation or prohibition (نَهْي) cannot be conceived as proceeding from one without power over them. This is established in theology (الكلام علم).

[38] Two conditions apply to the addressee (مَحْكُومٍ عَلَيْهِ); one is understanding the address containing a command or prohibition (نَهْي), since an obligatory demand cannot properly be directed to someone who does not understand the address (خِطَاب). If it is objected that alms and financial liabilities have been imposed upon children, we answer: the legally responsible person (مُكَلَّف) is the guardian, subject to readiness to receive reason (عَقْل). Likewise, in requiring children to pray before puberty, it is the father who is commanded. For only one who knows the Lawgiver (الشارع) understands the Law (شَرْع)'s address, and only one who knows God knows the Lawgiver. This condition (شَرْط) is apprehended by reason.

From this it becomes clear that legal responsibility lapses for the forgetful, the heedless, the insane, and the intoxicated. If it is asked why an intoxicated person's divorce takes effect according to those who allow it, we answer that this is a measure of severity: he has brought the harm upon himself by his own choice, after [possessing] reason (عَقْل), the condition (شَرْط) of legal responsibility (تَكْلِيف). Such a case cannot be conceived for an insane person. As for appealing, in support of the possibility of addressing the intoxicated, to His words—blessed and exalted is He—'Do not approach prayer while you are intoxicated': even if this apparent meaning is conceded in the verse, apparent meanings (الظواهر) are not set against certainties. The verse admits interpretations:

[39] One interpretation is that the address (خِطَاب) is directed to a person in the early stages of intoxication.

[40] Another is that what was prohibited was excessive drinking at the times of prayer: the address (خِطَاب) was issued while the hearers were in a sound (صَحِيح) state, before wine was prohibited.

[41] They append the objection: how can God eternally command His servants, when a condition of commanding is that the commanded person exist? Similarly, how can He command the intoxicated while intoxicated, or the insane and the child, on condition (شَرْط) that the first recover consciousness, the second become sound, and the third reach puberty? An answer is not possible in this place, nor is the question peculiar to this inquiry. Discussing it rests on principles requiring lengthy preparation and extensive examination (نَظَر). As we have said, we should not investigate everything, or many things, in a single place; each should receive its own treatment in the place appropriate to it. What prompts this practice is a love of multiplying material that serves no purpose.

[42] The second condition is puberty, and this condition (شَرْط) is apprehended through the Law (شَرْع). If it is asked whether a boy is not rational shortly before his first nocturnal emission, since the emission of semen does not add to his reason, we answer: because the attainment of reason is difficult to discern in each individual and its timing varies, the Law appointed a sign that indicates it in most cases.

[43] That concerning which the ruling is made, namely the act (فِعْل), is what can be acquired by the servant through his choice, while believing that its acquisition is obedience and compliance.

[44] It should be understood that the things a human being acquires are those in which he may perform whichever of two contraries he wishes: standing, for example, is acquired by him, and he may stand or sit. If this is the meaning (مَعْنَى) of acquisition (الاكتساب), there is no point in their purported exception for the obligation of inquiry that leads to knowledge, on the ground that one cannot intend to perform it as obedience before knowing it to be obligatory. For, as we have said, the obligation to inquire arises necessarily because the object of inquiry (نَظَر) is necessarily known. A person has no choice in assenting to its obligatoriness when the miracle appears.

Nor is there any point in their exception for the will to obey, or their saying that if willing required a will, that will would require another will, producing an infinite regress. Will (إِرَادَة) is desire (شوق), and the arising of desire in a human being is something like a necessary (ضَرُورِيّ) occurrence, since its producer is assent involving hope and fear. Thus the condition (شَرْط) of a legally prescribed act (فِعْل) is, first, that it be acquired; and second, that the cause (سَبَب) in acquiring [the act] be belief (تَصْدِيق) in the command's obligatoriness, [rather than] other things he may do.

[45] For the shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan, however, being acquired is not a condition (شَرْط) of an act (فِعْل). He holds that there is no act acquired by the human being at all: what makes the human being appear to be an agent of something is an accompanying and incidental matter, without the human being being either its proximate or its remote cause (سَبَب). Thus, for example, the relation of someone with two feet to walking would be exactly that of someone without feet. This contradicts sense perception (حِسّ) and is a view exceedingly foreign to human nature. Abū al-Maʿālī, in al-Risāla al-Niẓāmiyya, explained the respect in which one may properly say, within the Law (شَرْع), that human beings possess capacity and acquisition (اقتدارا واكتسابا).

Whoever denies human beings capacity for anything allows the imposition of what is beyond their capacity; he is right to do so on his own account, since on his view nothing is within their capacity. What we should say here is that imposing what is beyond capacity is impossible both rationally and legally. Legally, because of His saying, 'God charges no soul beyond its capacity.' Rationally, because the impossible cannot be present in the soul, and because a condition (شَرْط) of what is commanded is that it be understood and its possibility conceived by both the commander and the commanded.

[46] Several questions may be appended to the end of this part:

[47] One question is whether someone coerced into compliance with, or violation of, a legal requirement (التكليف) acts by choice, so as to be rewarded for the one and punished for the other. We say: someone coerced into compliance may reasonably be thought to act (فِعْل) by choice insofar as he can do otherwise and endure the means of coercion. This varies with the harm inflicted upon him. Yet if he does not perform the act believing it to be obedience and compliance, he receives no reward; if he does believe this, he is rewarded. Even when coercion initially moves him to act, if, upon undertaking the act, he believes its performance to be obedience, he is rewarded.

It is in this respect that coercing unbelievers to faith by [the threat of] killing occurs in the Law (شَرْع). In general, threatening punishment is a kind of coercion in this respect. Such a case is conceivable when obstinacy or some other impediment prevents a person from complying. In general, the soul that commands evil often turns a person away from a duty even while he believes it obligatory (وَاجِب).

As for someone coerced into violating the Law (شَرْع)—for example, into killing a Muslim or omitting prayer—there are two questions. First, does he sin if he acts as the coercion demands? Second, if he endures the coercion and does not act

(فِعْل) as it demands, is he rewarded or does he sin, given that a person's own life has a claim upon him?

What should be said is that coercion varies in degree according to its means. Apprehending these degrees, comparing them with violation of the command, and preferring (تَرْجِيح) one over the other are matters apprehended through the Law, especially when the means of coercion is of the same kind as the act demanded—for example, coercion by killing into killing. In general, this question is a matter of independent judgement (اجتهادية).

[48] Another question is whether the imposition of legal responsibility (التكليف) requires restraint just as action (فِعْل) is required. The answer is that omission is of two kinds. In one, a person, when omitting something, engages in its contrary (ضِدّ); this is rewarded, as in fasting. In the other, omitting something does not involve engagement in a contrary; this is not rewarded. Assigning each individual case to one of these two kinds belongs to inquiry (نَظَر) into the branches of law.

[49] Another question is whether the command to do something, such as the command to pray, applies before its condition is fulfilled, so that omission is punishable even without fulfilment of the condition (شَرْط). This concerns a legal condition: for example, commanding a ritually impure person to pray while impure. Or does the command apply only after the condition is fulfilled, as when prayer is commanded in a state of purity?

We say: if a person can acquire the condition by choice, he may be commanded to perform the act on the supposition that its condition is fulfilled and punished for omitting it even if he has not fulfilled the condition (شَرْط). Someone who omits prayer is punished for it even if he has never performed ablution. So the Law (شَرْع) has prescribed.

The proof (دَلِيل) of consensus (إِجْمَاع) indicates that punishment attaches to one who denies the messengers even before knowing God, although such knowledge is a condition of faith in the messengers. Some appealed here to His words—mighty and exalted—'What brought you into Saqar? They said: We were not among those who pray.' They sought to establish that the verse contains unambiguous wording (نص) on this. Although it is not unambiguous, this is its apparent meaning (ظاهرة), since 'those who pray' may here mean believers, as in his saying—peace be upon him—'I have been forbidden to kill those who pray.' Anyone who considers such a case rationally impossible interprets the apparent meaning (ظَاهِر) otherwise, as is usual with an apparent expression that admits alternatives.

[50] Those who disallow imposing responsibility in such a case argued that there is no meaning (مَعْنَى) in obliging almsgiving and the discharge of prayer when their occurrence is impossible: how can something be obligatory when it cannot be complied with? These people have confused a legal condition (الشرط الشرعي) with a condition of actual existence (الشرط الوجودي). The matter is otherwise. The command applies to this responsible person before its condition is fulfilled only on the supposition that the condition will be fulfilled; this is within his capacity and can be acquired, unlike a condition of actual existence.

[51] Their argument that, when an unbeliever becomes Muslim, the obligation concerning [past] prayer and almsgiving falls away contains no proof. We hold that this obligation lapses upon conversion only on the basis of a legal proof (دَلِيل). We require make-up performance (القضاء) from an apostate but not from an unbeliever because make-up performance becomes obligatory only through a separate command; the legal proof (حُجَّة) must therefore be followed. Thus someone not commanded to perform an act within its time (الأداء) may be commanded to make it up, while someone commanded to perform it within its time may not be commanded to make it up.

[52] They append a fourth question to this topic: just as a command to combine two contraries is inadmissible, so is a command to abstain from both when there is no intermediate between them.

[53] They claim, however, that certain particular (جُزْئِيّ) cases cast doubt on this universal (كُلِّيّ) proposition. One concerns someone in the middle of a usurped cultivated field: both remaining and leaving are forbidden, since each damages another person's crop, and whichever he does he is disobedient. Another concerns someone who falls on the chest of a child surrounded by children, knowing that if he remains he will kill the child beneath him, and if he moves he will kill those around him.

Such questions are matters of independent judgement. They cast no doubt on the inadmissibility of a command to abstain from both contraries. It may plausibly be said that the person is not legally responsible in this condition. Or it may be said that in the first case he should leave to reduce the harm, and in the second remain, since moving is a new act (فِعْل) that can proceed only from a living person. It is also possible to say that he has a choice, especially if neither act is preferable to the other in causing less harm. Here the discussion of the act, the third section of this book's first part, ends.

Discussion of the Fourth Section

[54] This section discusses the existence of causes that manifest both rulings and attributes characterizing rulings (ولصفات للأحكام أسبابا مظهرة), such as validity (صَحِيح) and invalidity (فَسَاد). It also explains what these names signify. It consists of four chapters.

First Chapter: Causes That Manifest Rulings

[55] Know that the Law (شَرْع) has appointed signs for rulings that entail their occurrence as perceptible causes entail their effects. Through these causes we come to know that rulings obtain; otherwise establishing them would be impossible. The detailed account of the conditions under which they entail rulings belongs to the third part of this book.

Second Chapter: What 'Validity' and 'Nullity' Signify in Rulings

[56] Know that these terms are applied to acts of worship (عِبَادَة) in different ways. For theologians, validity (الصحة) applies to what occurs in conformity with the Law (شَرْع), whether make-up performance (قَضَاء) is obligatory or not; for jurists, it applies to what suffices and removes the requirement of make-up performance. Thus the prayer of someone who thought himself ritually pure is valid in the theologians' terminology, since make-up performance is required by a renewed command. These are terminological conventions about which there is no dispute once the intended meaning is understood.

In contracts, invalidity (الفساد) applies to every legal determination (حُكْم) lacking something indispensable to its completion, whether a condition or a cause; validity is its opposite. Abū Ḥanīfa's followers, however, reserve 'defective' (الفاسد) for what is authorized in its foundation but prohibited in its attribute. We have already said that everything prohibited through its attribute is prohibited in its foundation and invalidated insofar as it bears that attribute. In general, rulings are characterized by validity (صَحِيح) only when carried out with the matters and conditions that the Law (شَرْع) requires for their performance; invalidity is the contrary.

Third Chapter: Describing Worship as Timely Performance, Make-Up Performance, and Repetition

[57] Know that when an obligation (وَاجِب) is discharged within its time, it is called timely performance (فِعْل) (أداء). If performed once with some defect and then performed again, it is called repetition (إعادة). If discharged after its restricted or extended time has elapsed, having been deliberately omitted, it is called make-up performance (قضاء). The name qaḍāʾ is also applied to other meanings, some closer to this meaning (مَعْنَى) and some more remote. One concerns what is omitted inadvertently until its time elapses. This too is properly called make-up performance, but differs from the first case in that its performer is relieved of sin.

Another concerns cases where timely performance (أَدَاء) is not obligatory, such as fasting for a menstruating woman. This puzzled some people to the point that they inferred an obligation to fast during menstruation from the obligation to make up the fast. Consensus (إِجْمَاع) refutes this: if she died before becoming ritually pure, she would not have sinned. Another concerns the sick person and the traveller. Since they are permitted to fast, their duty resembles an obligation (وَاجِب) with an extended time. This ought not to be called make-up performance (قَضَاء), just as praying at the end of the allotted period is not called make-up performance. Such usage is figurative (مَجَاز), because the familiar first period has been missed.

[58] There are two other doctrines concerning the traveller and the sick person. The Ẓāhirīs hold that if they fast, their fast is invalid, because of His words—mighty and exalted—'then a number of other days.' Al-Karkhī holds that the obligation (وَاجِب) concerns other days, but that fasting during Ramaḍān is valid, like advancing the alms before

the year's completion. Both doctrines rest upon declining to recognise an ellipsis in the verse, whose understood wording is ‘and he breaks the fast, then a number of other days,’ and to construe it as a concession (رخصة). This question will become clear from the discussion in the third part of this book.

Someone who construes it as a concession (رُخْصَة) might be asked about the validity of fasting by a sick person who fears death or severe harm to himself. That is a matter of independent judgement admitting either answer, and lies outside the present purpose.

[59] The Qāḍī—may God have mercy upon him—applied the name ‘make-up performance (فِعْل)’ to what a person deliberately omits while predominantly expecting death before performing it, if events subsequently contradict that expectation. His reason is that the time is assessed according to the predominant probability (غَلَبَة الظَّنّ). This is meaningless, since expecting death does not cause the allotted time itself to elapse.

Fourth Chapter: The Original Requirement and the Concession

[60] Know that the original requirement (العزم) in the Law (شَرْع) designates what binds servants through God's imposition of obligation. A concession (الرخصة) designates the latitude granted to a legally responsible person (مُكَلَّف) in acting because of an excuse or incapacity, while the prohibiting cause (سَبَب) remains in place: for example, permitting a draught of wine to someone choking, or carrion to someone compelled by necessity. ‘Concession’ may also be applied to other meanings, some closer to this meaning (مَعْنَى) and some more remote.

[61] Here inquiry (نَظَر) into the first part of this abridgement ends. The book on the sources (أَصْل) of rulings follows.

Part II · Sources of rulings

Discussion of the Second Part of This Book

[62] This part comprises inquiry (نَظَر) into the sources on which these rulings rest and from which they are derived. They are four: the Book, the Sunna (سُنَّة), the community's consensus (إِجْمَاع), and reason (عَقْل)'s indication (دَلِيل) of original (أَصْل) negation (النفي الأصلي). Calling the last a source is figurative, since it indicates the absence of rulings rather than rulings themselves. The status of a Companion's statement and the law of those before us is disputed. Let us begin with the Book, examining first its reality, then what delimits it, then its expressions, and then its rulings.

The First Source

[63] As for its reality and meaning, ‘it is the speech subsisting in the essence of God Most High, an eternal attribute among His attributes.’ Establishing this attribute and distinguishing it from the other attributes by what is peculiar to it belongs to theology (الكلام علم).

[64] Its limits comprise what has been transmitted to us between the two covers of the codex in the seven well-known aḥruf (الأحرف السبعة, modes of recitation), through recurrent transmission (نَقْل) (نقلا متواترا, tawātur), also called mass transmission (تَوَاتُر). We specified the codices because the Companions—may God be pleased with them—took the utmost precaution in transmitting it in writing. We required recurrent transmission because it yields certainty (يَقِين). What lies outside this and has not been recurrently transmitted is not part of it. It is impossible according to ordinary experience that any portion should be neglected or transmitted only by isolated reports, despite its wide circulation within a community incapable of such neglect or omission, whose transmission establishes recurrence.

Hence, contrary to Abū Ḥanīfa, most scholars hold that additions not recurrently transmitted (نَقْل) do not require action—for example, consecutiveness in expiation and similar matters. These additions do not stand in the position of solitary reports (أخبار الآحاد), since a report has neither a contrary indication (دَلِيل) nor evidence that it is false. If these additions are not considered Qurʾān, they may represent a Companion's doctrine or may be a report; action may not be based on something hovering between these two possibilities.

For this reason the Qāḍī—may God have mercy upon him—declared al-Shāfiʿī—may God have mercy upon him—definitely mistaken in treating ‘In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate’ as a verse of every sūra, although it is a verse of al-Naml. Had that been so, an explicit statement of its being Qurʾān would have been transmitted (نَقْل) to us and no disagreement would have arisen. Al-Shāfiʿī can argue that its placement at a sūra's beginning by the command

of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace— and its revelation at the beginning of each sūra, are contextual indicators suggesting that it belongs to the Qur'ān; if it did not, this would have been stated expressly.

The invocation of refuge, the qunūt supplication, and similar expressions are different: it was expressly stated that they are not part of the Qur'ān. In general, this is a question for independent judgement, which is why the Qāḍī did not pronounce unbelief on its account. Even so, it has little usefulness for deriving rulings. Al-Shāfiʿī required recitation of 'In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate' in prayer only because of reports (خَبَر) transmitted to that effect.

[65] As for its expressions, some are literal (حقيقة) and some figurative (مجاز). Their presence is evident, since it is in the Arabs' language and tongue. In general, I do not think any tongue or language lacks them, though languages differ in this regard. Some deny, and others allow, that its vocabulary contains anything outside Arabic; determining this contributes little to our present undertaking. In general, if Arabic contains an expression (لَفْظ) originally foreign to it, the Arabs have Arabized and altered it in a manner entitling it to count as part of their language and to be attributed to it.

Its expressions include determinate and ambiguous wording (محكم ومتشابه), as He—mighty and exalted—has said. People have disagreed about the ambiguous. It is preferable to consider ambiguous expressions to be those capable of bearing more than one meaning (مَعْنَى); or those whose apparent (ظَاهِر) interpretation suggests a contradiction among them; or expressions for whose meanings the Arabs had no prior convention or established usage, such as the letters at the beginnings of sūras; or all of these.

Discussion of the Second Source: The Sunna

[66] The saying of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—is an authoritative proof (حجة), because the miracle indicates his truthfulness. It is a proof in itself for anyone who heard him directly. We, however, receive his sayings—God bless him and grant him peace—only through transmitters, either by recurrent transmission (نَقْل) (التواتر) or through solitary reports (خَبَر) (الآحاد). The discussion of reports therefore divides into these two sections. Common to both is an explanation (بَيَان) of the ranks of the expressions used by the Companions—may God be pleased with them—in transmitting reports from him—God bless him and grant him peace. These ranks are as follows:

[67] The first is for the Companion to say, 'I heard God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace,' 'He related to me,' 'He informed me,' or 'He spoke to me directly.' This admits no alternative possibility.

[68] The second rank is to say, 'God's Messenger said such-and-such,' or 'He related such-and-such.' When this comes from a Companion, its apparent meaning is direct transmission (نَقْل), but it is not explicit, unambiguous wording (نصا صريحا), since the Companion may have been told it on the authority of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace. Most nevertheless regard acting on such a report as permissible because of the contextual indicators supporting it, especially when it comes from someone whose companionship with him was extensive.

[69] The third rank is for the Companion to say, 'God's Messenger commanded such-and-such,' 'prohibited such-and-such,' 'prescribed such-and-such,' or 'made such-and-such obligatory (فَرْض).' Two possibilities arise: one concerns whether he heard it, as with the expression 'he said' [the printed cross-reference is defective]; the second concerns his understanding the address (خِطَاب) as command or obligation, since the imperative form (صِيغَة) is disputed. Hence Dāwūd and those Ẓāhirīs who followed him held that the Companion's statement is no authoritative proof (حُجَّة) unless he transmits the actual words of the Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace.

It has been argued against them that this is an inquiry (نَظَر) into understanding expressions. Disagreement about them arises among us because we are neither masters of eloquent Arabic nor authorities for Arabic speech (كَلَام). But since the Companion is an Arab, how could he be suspected of error concerning the imperative form (صِيغَة), when his usage itself supplies authoritative evidence (حُجَّة) in a dispute about it?

[70] We consider that establishing correct expressions in a language for someone who is not a native speaker occurs in one of two ways: by

induction (اسْتِقْرَاء) from its speakers' discourse, or by transmission from them where the usage is widespread among them. Accordingly, one person's statement cannot serve as authoritative evidence until it becomes widely circulated. Whether recurrent transmission (نَقْل) is required in transmitting a language, or solitary reports suffice, is disputed. It seems that solitary transmission suffices for much of it; otherwise there would be no way to ascertain most verbal significations if recurrent transmission were required for each expression.

[71] The fourth rank is to say, 'We were commanded to do such-and-such,' or 'We were prohibited from such-and-such.' Besides the preceding possibilities, this admits another: the person issuing the command may have been someone other than the Prophet—God bless him and grant him peace—among the leaders and rulers. Their expressions 'Such-and-such belongs to the Sunna (سُنَّة)' and 'The Sunna proceeds in such-and-such a way' have the same import.

[72] The fifth rank is for a Companion to say, 'They used to do such-and-such,' relating the practice to the time of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace. This too admits the possibility that the practice reached the notice of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—and he approved it, which is the more apparent possibility; it also admits the possibility that it did not reach him.

[73] From this it has become clear what constitutes reporting from God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—and what does not.

[74] It remains now to explain how reports (خَبَر) reach us: either through recurrent transmission (نَقْل) or through solitary transmission. Let us discuss both and the rank of the assent (التصديق) arising from each, beginning with recurrent transmission. We say:

[75] Recurrent transmission (التواتر) is a widely circulated report (خَبَر) from which certainty arises about certain matters and under certain conditions, without our knowing whence, how, or when it arose. We said 'about certain (يَقِين) matters' because it does not arise concerning intelligibles that are not by nature perceptible, or things whose analogues are perceptible but which cannot exist—such as a goat-stag and other things having no existence outside the soul. Nor does it arise concerning something possibly existent that is to be perceived in the future.

Rather, it yields certainty only about what has determinate existence now, or had determinate existence in the past, among things we have not yet ourselves perceived. Recurrent transmission has no use concerning what we have perceived or can apprehend through a certain (يَقِين) syllogism (يقيني قياس), such as the world's coming into being and other matters. For if what is recurrently reported accords with what we perceived or established syllogistically, it is superfluous for us; if the contrary is recurrently reported, no assent (تَصْدِيق) arises in us from it.

Our phrase 'under certain conditions' guards against cases where reports are recurrent but certainty does not arise. On recognising this, some sought to require a number of transmitters from which certainty follows essentially and primarily, so that the number itself causes certainty and necessitates it as causes necessitate their effects. When they could not ascertain such a number, they defined it as that from which certainty (يَقِين) arises, supposing that it has a determinate existence in itself even though it remains unknown to us.

Observation shows otherwise. The number from which certainty arises evidently increases and decreases from one case to another. If there were some number that by nature produced certainty (يَقِين) essentially and primarily, we would perceive and identify it. In general, a multiplicity of informants is one of the contextual indicators (القرائن) producing assent (تَصْدِيق). The number must therefore increase or decrease according to the other contextual indicators joined to it.

[76] If this is so, we cannot say that assent to this conclusion is produced, in the primary sense, by premises; rather, it comes about in the manner in which the first intelligibles are said to arise from sense perception (حِسّ). Anyone who supposes that recurrent transmission is like experiential premises—whose universality becomes certain (يَقِين) through deliberately perceiving their particulars—is definitely mistaken. Rather, the assent (تَصْدِيق) arising from recurrent transmission is an act (فِعْل) of the soul, and its relation to the soul resembles that of ⟨the first intelligibles to sense perception⟩.

In general, [no one has disputed that recurrent transmission produces certainty except those who deserve no consideration, namely the sophists. Someone who denies it needs punishment, since his tongue lies about what is in his soul. The disagreement concerns only how certainty arises from it: some hold that it arises essentially (بالذات), some incidentally (بالعرض), and some through acquisition.] Such is the view held here by Abū Ḥāmid and those following him: certainty (يَقِين) arises only after two premises. The first is that, despite their differing circumstances, nothing unites these informants in falsehood; the second, that they have agreed in reporting this event.

Abū Ḥāmid nevertheless concedes that these two premises were never actually formed in the mind, and that a person did not need to summon them when assent (تَصْدِيق) arose through recurrent transmission.

[77] If this is posited—and it is undoubtedly what is observed in recurrent transmission—it is evident that these two premises play no useful part in producing certainty (يَقِين). What does not actually exist in the soul cannot cause what is potential in it to exist by bringing it into actuality. If the major premise (مُقَدِّمَة) in the first figure were not actually present in the soul, it would not cause the conclusion to arise from it, although that conclusion was potentially contained within it.

What benefit, then, is there in requiring something that exists in this manner to produce assent? Hence we stipulated in the definition (حَدّ) of recurrent transmission that we do not know how or whence it arose. In general, reports (خَبَر) and testimonies generally yield only probable judgement (ظنا), varying with the contextual indicators until, in some cases, certainty (يَقِين) arises. People therefore differ about the ranks of assent (تَصْدِيق) produced by reports according to their accompaniments. For example, some place a single person's report before a group at the level of recurrent transmission if the group refrains from contradicting him, its numbers ordinarily preclude collusion in sanctioning falsehood, and they have apprehended the reported matter through sense perception (حِسّ).

There are also contextual indicators that weaken the probable (ظَنّ) judgement (حُكْم) arising from reports until, in some cases, their falsehood becomes almost certain. An example is someone reporting that the city's king was killed in the marketplace, after which the people of the market pass by without speaking of it. Of this kind (جِنْس) is Abū Ḥanīfa's rejection—may God have mercy upon him—of solitary reports (خَبَر) concerning rulings of widespread practical concern: he considers that matters of such concern ought to be widely transmitted. Likewise, Mālik rejected many reports when practice did not accompany them.

[78] This is what should be said about the rank of assent (تَصْدِيق) arising from reports (خَبَر), and about the cases in which they are useful and those in which they are not.

[79] As for a solitary report (خَبَر الْوَاحِد) (الآحاد خبر), according to its definition (حَدّ) in this craft (صِنَاعَة), it is what has not reached the point of yielding certainty … [the construction is defective] … in some case through a single person's report, according to the contextual indicators accompanying it. We answer: although this is not impossible, it occurs rarely, perhaps for a particular person in a particular case. Because the probable judgement (ظَنّ) arising in the soul varies when contextual indicators accompany solitary reports, some held that a single person's report may yield certainty (يَقِين).

[80] After defining a solitary report (خَبَر الْوَاحِد), its discussion also includes whether the Law permits acting upon it, the conditions of its transmitters, criticism and accreditation (والتعديل الجرح), and the manner in which a transmitter reports (خَبَر) from his source.

First Chapter: The Legal Admissibility of Acting on a Solitary Report

[81] Acting upon solitary reports (خَبَر) is rationally possible and actually occurs in the Law. As for its admissibility in the Law (شَرْع), it is not impossible for God Most High to appoint predominant probability (غلبة الظن) as a sign of a ruling (حُكْم), just as He appoints other things as signs. On this basis one can conceive adjudication through witnesses, judgement by legal opinion, and facing the Kaʿba when it is not visible. Some held that appointing predominant probability (ظَنّ) as a sign of a legal ruling is rationally necessary; otherwise most rulings would lapse for anyone who had not heard God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—directly.

Abū Ḥāmid says this argument is not strong, since one could say that rulings lapse for those whom recurrent transmission has not reached, just as they lapse for those who have neither heard of the Law nor received it by recurrent transmission. I do not find this satisfactory. The Law (شَرْع)'s remaining hidden is exceedingly rare, scarcely occurring over a long period; its recurrent transmission to the entire inhabited world has necessarily taken place. Such concealment might plausibly have occurred at the beginning of Islam. Acting on solitary reports (خَبَر) is different: not every report must necessarily be recurrently transmitted, and requiring recurrence before acting would suspend most rulings for most legally responsible persons.

In general, if adjudicating through witnesses and oaths, and judging by independent judgement (حُكْم), were not obligatory, there would be no way to redress wrongs and secure rights. Its occurrence in the Law can also be inferred from the Companions' consensus (إِجْمَاع) on acting upon such reports. Their hesitation concerning some reports (خَبَر) was merely their independent assessment of the routes of transmission. The fact that God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—sent governors to the provinces and charged people to accept their reports establishes its occurrence in the Law with certainty.

[82] Some regard His words—mighty and exalted—'Why should not a group from every division of them go forth, to gain understanding in religion and warn their people when they return to them?' as decisive concerning acting upon solitary reports (خَبَر). A 'group' can mean a few people whose statements do not yield certainty (يَقِين). Abū Ḥāmid considers the verse decisive only concerning the obligation to warn. He says that their obligation to warn does not entail an obligation to act upon it, just as a single witness must testify although his testimony is not acted upon.

He adds that the same objection weakens appeals to His words—mighty and exalted— 'Those who conceal what We have sent down of clear proofs and guidance,' and to the saying of the Messenger —God bless him and grant him peace— 'May God make radiant one who hears my words, retains them, and conveys them as he heard them,' and the rest of the report. This statement of his has no meaning (مَعْنَى). What is the benefit of requiring warning if acting on their transmission is not obligatory? It is not like a witness's case: he is obliged to testify in the hope that another person with matching testimony will come forward, allowing it to be acted upon.

One might reply that warning was perhaps required of individuals only so that their numbers would increase until their statements produced necessary (ضَرُورِيّ) knowledge. But this is refuted by the preceding point: it would suspend most rulings. It is more plausible to regard the verse as neither decisive nor unambiguous wording (نصا) for acting upon solitary reports because 'group' applies both to a few people and to a large number whose statements can yield certainty (يَقِين), as indicated by the saying, 'A group of my community will continue …' and the rest of the report (خَبَر). The verse's more apparent meaning, however, is that 'group' here does not mean people whose transmission produces knowledge (عِلْم).

Second Chapter: The Transmitter's Condition and Character

[83] Since acting on a solitary report (خَبَر الْوَاحِد) has been established, the conditions under which it is accepted and must be acted upon must be stated, for not every report requires action. First, a single person's report (خَبَر) is acted upon even where his testimony is not. Once acting on such a report is established, whoever requires a plurality must prove that requirement from the Law; it cannot properly be assimilated to testimony by analogy (قياسا). The Companions—may God be pleased with them—sought corroboration through numbers on two or three occasions as their independent judgement in circumstances particular to those cases. In general, we do not require a plurality as a condition (شَرْط).

[84] The first condition (شَرْط) is that we do not accept a child's report, because he does not fear God and we cannot be assured against his lying. If, however, he was a child when he heard the report and transmits it after puberty, it is accepted. The proof (دَلِيل) is the Companions' consensus (إِجْمَاع) on acting upon reports (خَبَر) without distinguishing whether they were heard in childhood or after puberty. Those who accept children's testimony concerning injuries occurring among them are led to do so by inference (اسْتِدْلَال) from contextual indicators arising from their numbers; hence they

require their testimony to be given before they disperse.

[85] Another condition (شَرْط) is accurate retention (ضابطا), since someone inattentive will usually fall into error. There is no disagreement about requiring the transmitter to be Muslim: an unbeliever's transmission is not accepted because he is suspect concerning religion. Although Abū Ḥanīfa accepts unbelievers' testimony concerning one another, there is no dissent from rejecting their transmission. In general, the basis for rejecting it is consensus (إِجْمَاع).

[86] The requirement of probity (العدالة) is undisputed, but what its name signifies is disputed. Some, who are the majority, hold that probity is a state of the soul (حالة في النفس) from which follows avoidance of what the Law prohibits, whether by forbiddance or disapproval (كَرَاهَة), and performance of what the Law (شَرْع) commands, whether by obligation or recommendation (نَدْب), without falling short in this.

[87] In general, he must avoid everything that impugns his religion and whose commission leaves lying open to him. This varies according to the assessments of those exercising independent judgement. There is, however, no disagreement that sinlessness is not required, just as avoiding grave sins is not sufficient. Some hold that probity (عَدَالَة) consists in manifesting Islam while not being known as morally transgressive, without investigation (نَظَر) into one's conduct or inward condition.

[88] The proponents of the first doctrine argued: just as transmission is inadmissible from someone whose status concerning unbelief is unknown, so it is from someone whose status concerning moral transgression is unknown. Their opponents may reply that, in the former case, no state is known that produces predominant confidence in his trustworthiness, whereas a person known to manifest Islam is different. The first group also appealed to the Companions' rejection of reports (خَبَر) from unknown persons—ʿUmar's rejection—may God be pleased with him—of Fāṭima bt. Qays's report and ʿAlī's rejection of al-Ashjaʿī's statement—and to the evident demand of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—for probity (عَدَالَة) and trustworthiness in those he sent to the provinces.

[89] The second group appealed to the fact that the Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—accepted a Bedouin's testimony that he had seen the crescent, although nothing was known of him except his Islam. Their opponents need not concede that he was unknown to the Prophet himself. They also argued that the Companions accepted the statements of people whom they knew as Muslims and did not know to be morally transgressive.

[90] In general, each group has advanced arguments that, although apparently supporting its claim, still admit interpretation (تَأْوِيل). The question concerns independent judgement, not certainty. What is intended (مَقْصُود) by probity (عَدَالَة), it appears, is simply a predominant probability (غَلَبَة الظَّنّ) of truthfulness; this varies with the contextual indicators supplied by the circumstances.

Where the Law (شَرْع) has not established with certainty a determinate sign of predominant probability (غَلَبَة الظَّنّ) concerning truthfulness, we should therefore impose no fixed limit. The matter should be entrusted to the inquiry (نَظَر) of those exercising independent judgement. Contextual indicators may come together for one such jurist (مُجْتَهِد) that make a person's truthfulness predominantly probable (ظَنّ) to him, while they do not come together for another.

[91] They have disagreed about a morally transgressive person who acts on an interpretation (الفاسق المتأول), meaning someone who does not recognise his own transgression. Whoever holds that transgression prevents acceptance only because it arouses suspicion cannot conceive rejecting him unless his transgression consists in permitting lying. Whoever holds that transgression in itself defeats acceptance, ⟨not⟩ because it arouses suspicion, permits their testimony concerning one another. The first is al-Shāfiʿī's doctrine; the second, the Qāḍī's. Al-Shāfiʿī's doctrine seems more consistent with the reasoning, and is supported by the Companions' acceptance—may God be pleased with them—of reports (خَبَر) from the Khārijites.

[92] The transgression of someone acting on an interpretation may be known through a certain (قَطْعِيّ) proof (دَلِيل) or through a probable proof. Acceptance of the transmission of someone whose transgression is established by a probable proof should be more appropriate. Hence al-Shāfiʿī says:

‘I judge the Ḥanafī who drinks nabīdh morally transgressive, but I do not reject his testimony.’

[93] These are the conditions required in a transmitter. As for the considerations through which preference (التِرجيح) is established, they are almost without limit.

Third Chapter: Criticism of Transmitters and Attestation of Their Probity

[94] This comprises four sections.

First Section

[95] Some require more than one person to attest a transmitter’s probity, by analogy with testimony; others do not, by analogy (قِيَاس) with the acceptance of a report transmitted by a person of probity. The latter is the more evident view.

Second Section: Stating the Grounds for Criticism and Attestation of Probity

[96] Al-Shāfiʿī says that the grounds for criticism (جَرْح) must be stated, whereas the grounds for attesting probity (عَدَالَة) need not be: one person may regard as a fault something that another does not, while probity has only one basis. Some hold the reverse, because people are quick to praise on the strength of appearances. The Qāḍī says that the grounds need not be stated in either case, reliance being placed on the person giving the attestation (تَعْدِيل). Others say that the grounds must be stated in both cases. This is, in my view, the more cautious course, since assessments of probity and the weighing of evidence are both disputed, as was explained earlier.

When criticism conflicts with an attestation of probity (تَعْدِيل), criticism (جَرْح) takes precedence, because it discloses additional (زِيَادَة) information unknown to the person attesting probity—unless the latter specifically addresses the very matter asserted by the critic. In that case, criticism and attestation stand in conflict (تَعَارُض).

Third Section: Attestation and Confirmation of Probity Themselves

[97] This can take four forms: through an explicit statement, through transmitting a report from someone, through acting upon his report, or through giving judgement (حُكْم) on his testimony. The highest is an explicit statement explaining the basis of his probity; below this is transmitting a report from him. The latter is valid only on the view that an attestation by itself suffices to establish probity, and only when the transmission is understood as an explicit declaration of the narrator’s confidence in the person from whom he reports (خَبَر). Acting upon a report, however, does not attest the transmitter’s probity, since the action may rest on another proof (دَلِيل)—unless we know that he acted on that report as received through that particular transmitter. This, too, follows the view that the grounds for criticism (جَرْح) and attestation (تَعْدِيل) need not be stated.

Giving judgement (حُكْم) on someone’s testimony is stronger than merely attesting his probity. Declining to give judgement on his testimony or report is not, however, a criticism (جَرْح) of him: one may withhold acceptance of an upright person’s testimony or report for reasons other than an objection to his probity. In general, when no other reason (سَبَب) presents itself for rejecting his testimony and transmission, the rejection is equivalent to an unspecified criticism.

Fourth Section: Attestation of the Companions’ Probity, May God Be Pleased with Them

[98] The position of the great majority of the community and its acknowledged authorities is that the Companions’ probity is established with certainty, through God’s attestation (تَعْدِيل) of it—majestic and mighty is He—and that of His Messenger, in numerous verses of the Book of God, majestic and mighty, and numerous reports from the Messenger, God bless him and grant him peace.

[99] Groups among the Khārijites, Muʿtazilites, and Qadarites—in general, the people of innovation and deviation—have rejected the Companions’ testimony and transmission after dissension arose among them and wars and disputes broke out. The people of the Sunna understand these events on the basis that every practitioner of independent judgement is either free of sin or correct, according to the two respective positions. Some of the people of the Sunna (سُنَّة) maintain that ʿUthmān’s killers were certainly mistaken, but did not recognise their error and were acting on an interpretation. According to the majority, the testimony of a wrongdoer acting on an interpretation is not rejected.

[100] Our account of the solitary report (خَبَر الْوَاحِد) still requires a discussion of the manner in which a transmitter reports (خَبَر) from the person who is his source. This can occur at five levels.

The First Level

101 The teacher reads to him so that he may transmit from the teacher. He may then truthfully say, in the literal sense (حَقِيقَة), 'He related to us,' 'He informed us,' and 'I heard him.' This is the highest level.

The Second Level

102 The report is read to the teacher while he remains silent. Some Literalists dispute this, but the majority consider his silence and approval equivalent to his speaking, provided there is no reason to suppose that his silence results from inattention, coercion, or the like. They disagree, however, about whether the transmitter may say without qualification, 'He related to us,' or 'I heard so-and-so.' The correct position is that he may not, since this is plainly false—unless a contextual indication (حال قرينة) or an explicit statement makes it known that he means a reading before the teacher.

The Third Level: Authorization

103 This is for the teacher to say, 'I authorize you to transmit from me such-and-such a book,' or 'Whatever you have reliably identified among the reports I have heard.' In such a case, 'He related to us' or 'He informed us' may be used without qualification only in an extended sense.

The Fourth Level: Handing Over a Written Text

104 Its form is for the teacher to say, 'Take this book and transmit it from me.' Merely handing it over without speaking has no significance; the physical handing over (مُنَاوَلَة) is therefore an additional (زِيَادَة) formality, and the transaction is in reality an authorization (إِجَازَة). Although it does not yield knowledge of the precise route of transmission, it does yield knowledge of the report (خَبَر)'s authenticity.

The Fifth Level: Reliance on Handwriting

105 He finds a statement in the teacher's handwriting: 'I transmitted such-and-such from so-and-so.' He may not transmit it from the teacher, because handwriting can be confused with other handwriting. If the teacher says, 'This is my handwriting,' his statement is accepted, but one may not transmit from him unless he gives permission verbally or by a contextual indication (قَرِينَة).

If a person of probity says, 'This is an accurate copy of al-Bukhārī's book,' and one sees in it 'He related to us,' one still may not transmit from its author. But must one act upon it? If one follows another's judgement, one must ask a practitioner of independent judgement; this is undisputed. If one exercises independent judgement oneself, some say that one may not act upon it without having heard it. Others say that one may act upon it once the copy's accuracy is known, since the Messenger's Companions, God bless him and grant him peace, carried written sheets to the provinces, and people relied upon them on the testimony of their bearers.

In general, however, one should transmit only what one has heard and ascertained: the person who transmitted to them entertained no doubt about anything they received from him. If he doubted anything, its transmission was abandoned.

106 Several questions branch from this. Suppose that among the reports recorded as having been heard by a transmitter there is one that he strongly believes he heard: may he transmit it? If he is in doubt, there is no disagreement that he may not. If he strongly believes that he heard it, some say that it may be received from him, since this field rests on predominant probability (غَلَبَة الظَّنّ). This is implausible: predominant probability concerns the teacher's truthfulness. Likewise, in testimony, predominant probability (ظَنّ) concerns the judge (حَاكِم); the witness, however, should testify with certainty wherever certainty is possible. The same applies to a transmitter.

107 Another question arises when the teacher denies the report categorically, affirming that the transmitter has spoken falsely. The report is then not acted upon, but the transmitter is not thereby discredited, because they are two persons of probity whose statements conflict (تَعَارُض). If, however, the teacher's denial expresses uncertainty, the report (خَبَر) is acted upon: the transmitter is certain that he heard it, while the teacher does not categorically declare him false, and both possess probity.

Al-Karkhī holds that the teacher's forgetting the report invalidates it. He argues that the teacher is not obliged to act upon it when a person of probity transmits it back to him from him and he does not remember it. The transmitter cannot be in this

position, since he is certain; the position of someone other than these two lies between theirs.

It seems that the report's recipient is more likely to believe the transmitter truthful, given how commonly people forget and the fact that the teacher does not categorically declare him false. This is the position of Mālik, al-Shāfiʿī, and the great majority of the theologians. In their view, it resembles the teacher's uncertainty about an addition (زِيَادَة) to a report or its grammatical inflection.

[108] Another question concerns a trustworthy transmitter who alone reports an addition to a report transmitted by a group of trustworthy persons with exact memories. Some say that the addition is accepted: if he alone had transmitted an entire report, it would have been accepted, and the addition is no different. You know that this is not so. His being alone in reporting an addition to a report they have also transmitted, despite their exact memories, is an indication (قرينة) weakening the probability (ظَنّ) of the addition (زِيَادَة)'s authenticity. This does not apply when he alone transmits an entire report.

Accordingly, some reject the addition; others accept it, though not for the reason just given. Their reason is that the others do not categorically deny the addition (زِيَادَة). They may have entered the gathering after part of the report had already been related, or they may have been present but failed to hear it because of some distraction or accident. In general, this is a matter for independent judgement, and its probability (ظَنّ) varies from case to case and report to report.

[109] Another question is the transmission (نَقْل) of a report's meaning without its wording. Some permit this for a learned person who understands the applications of speech. Others allow only the substitution (الإبدال) of an expression (لَفْظ) synonymous with and equal in meaning to the original: for example, replacing quʿūd with julūs, both meaning (مَعْنَى) 'sitting,' where their synonymy is beyond doubt, and not where establishing it requires inference (اسْتِدْلَال).

The first group appeals to the consensus (إِجْمَاع) permitting the meanings contained in the Law (شَرْع) to be explained to non-Arabs in their own languages. They say that if Arabic may be replaced by synonymous non-Arabic wording, replacing it with Arabic wording (لَفْظ) is all the more permissible. They do not distinguish between a substitution (إِبْدَال) whose validity is self-evident and one requiring inference (اسْتِدْلَال). They add that the Messenger of God's emissaries, God bless him and grant him peace, likewise conveyed his commands to non-Arabs.

[110] I hold that when understanding what expressions signify is a matter for independent judgement, a practitioner of independent judgement may not act upon a reported meaning until the Lawgiver's wording has been transmitted to him. Otherwise, in the very capacity in which he exercises independent judgement, he becomes a follower of someone else's judgement. An exception might be made where that meaning (مَعْنَى) is stated by a Companion; discussion of this returns to the disagreement mentioned earlier. A practitioner of independent judgement whose judgement others follow may, in my view, substitute one expression (لَفْظ) for another for those who follow him, since this itself is a kind of independent judgement. Consequently, explaining Arabic expressions and rendering them in another language are permissible.

As for permitting the transmission of only part of a report (خَبَر), [I consider this permissible if that part conveys a meaning, is self-sufficient, and does not require what precedes it in order to be understood, or if omitting the excised portion does not leave what remains susceptible to two or more meanings. This applies equally whether [we permit] the procedure on the view of those who allow transmission (نَقْل) of a report's meaning (مَعْنَى) without its wording (لَفْظ), or of those who do not].

[111] Another question concerns transmission with an omitted link and transmission (نَقْل) with a connected chain. Opinions differ: Mālik, Abū Ḥanīfa, and the majority accept and act upon a report with an omitted link, whereas al-Shāfiʿī and the Qāḍī reject it. Its form is for someone who was not his contemporary to say, 'The Messenger of God said'—God bless him and grant him peace—or for someone who was not Abū Hurayra's contemporary to say, 'Abū Hurayra said.'

The first group argues that transmission by a person of probity attests his source's probity (عَدَالَة), especially when he states this explicitly, as in 'from a trustworthy person,' in their usage. The reply is

that his transmission does not attest probity unless his circumstances indicate that he transmits only from persons of probity, or he expressly attests his source's probity; and even then it does not establish probity unless he states what probity means to him. In my view, this last requirement does not follow from the positions of al-Shāfiʿī and the Qāḍī, as explained earlier. Perhaps, however, they concede unspecified attestation (تَعْدِيل) only where the person is identified: an unidentified person might, if named, be someone we know to be morally unreliable.

The first group also argues for accepting reports with omitted links from the consensus (إِجْمَاع) of the Companions and Successors permitting action upon them. But the alleged consensus itself is disputed, because this position has not been transmitted from all of them, and the silence of those who said nothing does not have the standing of an express statement, especially in matters open to independent judgement, as will be explained later.

Some who reject reports with omitted links nevertheless accept such a report from a Companion, because he generally relates only from another Companion, and all of them possess probity. The same is said of the Successors' reports with omitted links, since they generally transmit from a Companion. The preferred position among those who reject such reports, however, is to accept one from neither a Companion nor a Successor until his explicit wording or a contextual indication (قَرِينَة) makes it known that he transmits only from a Companion.

An argument might be brought against those who refuse such reports from chains expressed simply by 'from,' which are treated as connected despite the possibility (إِمْكَان) of an intermediary between the transmitter and his source. They may reply that a chain expressed by 'from' is treated as connected only where accompanying indications show that the transmitter heard directly from his source, or where he explicitly says so. In the absence of either an explicit statement or such indications, the report remains uncertain between an omitted-link report and a connected report (مُسْنَد).

[112] As for accepting a solitary report (خَبَر الْوَاحِد) about something of widespread occurrence, such as the report concerning touching the penis and similar reports (خَبَر), the grounds for suspecting it have already been explained: what commonly affects people normally becomes widely circulated and known. Those who permit acting on solitary reports in such matters reject this indication. They say that widespread transmission is required only for what the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, was charged to disseminate among everyone; it is not required for what he was charged to convey to individuals while referring others to their reports.

To justify referring people to solitary reports (خَبَر) in some cases even though widespread transmission would be possible, they invoke the permissibility of referring them to analogy (قِيَاس) where an express ruling could have been given, as in the question of usury and similar matters. They say that widespread occurrence is not the cause (عِلَّة) of dissemination and wide transmission; the cause is the manner in which the duty is imposed.

[113] I hold that his conveying, God bless him and grant him peace, one of God's individually binding obligations to a single person, while refraining from conveying it to the Companions who attended him morning and evening—may God bless them and grant them peace—would involve his relying, God bless him and grant him peace, on their acting upon the report (خَبَر) if it reached them and on the obligation (وَاجِب)'s lapsing for them if it did not. Nothing in his circumstances, God bless him and grant him peace, indicates this, given his eagerness to teach and explain.

Whether or not such a thing is rationally possible, examining his conduct, God bless him and grant him peace, in explaining and clarifying the Law brings one close to certainty that it could not have occurred in the revealed dispensation.

The truth is that some reports can reach us only through solitary routes, even if their subject was formerly widespread and the reports (خَبَر) widely circulated. Others can reach us by either route, and still others cannot reach us except through mass transmission (تَوَاتُر). This varies from case to case and issue to issue, according to time, place, and other obstacles.

Accordingly, in some reports (خَبَر) a practitioner of independent judgement may find grounds for rejection because of widespread occurrence, while in others he may find no such grounds, especially in collective obligations. In each instance one

should judge according to what the matter under discussion admits. Rejecting solitary routes in every case of widespread occurrence is incorrect, since the matter varies with the accompanying indications; acting upon them without qualification is likewise incorrect.

This division does not have the nature of logical opposition, so that its two sides could be made contradictories and each party discuss them as though truth were confined to one side. You know how often they proceed in this way in many of these questions.

[114] Here the examination (نَظَر) of the second source (أَصْل), the Sunna (سُنَّة), comes to an end. You should know that both these sources are subject to abrogation (نَسْخ); let us now discuss it.

On the Abrogating and the Abrogated

[115] There is disagreement over the definition (حَدّ) of abrogation. The theologians define it as discourse indicating the removal of a ruling established by earlier discourse, such that the ruling (حُكْم) would remain in force without it, with the discourse indicating its removal occurring later. They include these qualifications because they allow that God Most High may remove a ruling at some time after, for example, commanding it in perpetuity. In general, they allow abrogation before performance (فِعْل) has become possible. Others define it as discourse (خِطَاب) disclosing when the term of an act of worship (عِبَادَة) expires, because they believe that abrogation (نَسْخ) merely clarifies a prescription that was never intended from the outset to apply generally to, or encompass, all time.

Still others define it as discourse indicating that a ruling (حُكْم) like the one established by the text (نَصّ) ceases to hold, such that it would remain in force without that discourse (خِطَاب). This definition (حَدّ) is somewhat clumsy, because it makes what is removed a ruling like the original rather than the ruling itself. They were driven to this formulation only because they do not allow that God Most High may prohibit the very same thing after commanding it.

[116] In general, inquiry into which of these things may or may not be attributed to God Most High does not belong to the jurist as jurist. It is sufficient for the jurist to concede and believe that the Law contains rulings removed after they had been commanded, whether or not this removal disclosed the expiry of the term of an act of worship (عِبَادَة), and that the occurrence of such abrogation in the Law (شَرْع) is established by mass transmission. Inquiry (نَظَر) into its rational possibility, or the manner of that possibility, does not belong specifically to him. Let us therefore begin with what is necessary (ضَرُورِيّ) in this discipline (صِنَاعَة). The discussion comprises several questions.

[117] If part of an act of worship, one of its conditions, or one of its recommended observances is abrogated (نَسْخ), does this abrogate the act of worship itself? Opinions differ. The truth is that removing a part removes the whole, because a whole is a whole through its parts, and an act of worship (عِبَادَة) is commanded insofar as it comprises all its parts. In general, removing a part removes the whole, since it no longer remains a whole; this applies to what cannot be divided into independent parts. Removing a condition (شَرْط) seems to have the same effect, since it is through that condition that the act of worship is complete. Removing a recommended observance, however, does not entail removing the act's obligatory character.

[118] Question. Some regard an addition to a text (نَصّ) as abrogation; others do not. The preferred position is that an addition constitutes abrogation (نَسْخ) when it makes what receives the addition different from what it was before and numerically a second thing. An example is prayer, if it is correct that two cycles were originally prescribed and further cycles were then added (زِيَادَة).

If, however, the addition differs in kind from the act of worship (عِبَادَة) to which it is added, it clearly is not abrogation—for example, prescribing prayer and then prescribing almsgiving. Likewise, if the addition and what receives it are one in kind, but the addition (زِيَادَة) does not make the latter a different individual thing, it is not abrogation (نَسْخ): for example, adding twenty lashes to a prescribed punishment of eighty. Abū Ḥanīfa, God have mercy on him, nevertheless regards such a case as abrogation.

[119] Question. Abrogation does not require establishing a substitute for the abrogated (نَسْخ) ruling to take its place and occupy its position.

Abrogation without such a substitute is permissible according to the people of the Sunna (سُنَّة) and has occurred in the Law, as in the abrogation concerning storing sacrificial meat and giving charity before private consultation.

As for God's saying, mighty and majestic, 'Whatever verse We abrogate or cause to be forgotten, We bring one better than it,' although its apparent meaning establishes a substitute taking the abrogated verse's place, 'We bring one better than it' may be interpreted to mean 'We bring another verse,' even if this does not contain a replacement for the abrogated verse in respect of its ruling (حُكْم), but instead contains another ruling that is not a substitute for the one removed.

[120] Question. Abrogation (نَسْخ) may replace a ruling with a lighter or a heavier one. This is rationally possible and has occurred in the Law. Examples of replacing a lighter requirement with a heavier one are replacing the choice between fasting and feeding others as compensation with fasting alone; prohibiting wine and temporary marriage; and replacing the fast of ʿĀshūrāʾ with the obligation to fast Ramaḍān.

[121] Question. When a verse contains a ruling, its recitation may be abrogated while its ruling remains, its ruling (حُكْم) may be abrogated while its recitation remains, or both may be abrogated (نَسْخ). This is rationally possible and has occurred in the Law. Its rational possibility follows because recitation comprises two aspects: first, reading the verse, writing it in the codex, and reciting it in prayer; second, the rulings it contains. A person may be charged with either aspect without the other, and both may be removed together, according to what the doctrines of the people of the Sunna (سُنَّة) entail.

Evidence from revelation that this has occurred is God's saying, 'For those who are able to bear it, a compensation: food for needy people,' and the rest of the verse. Its ruling was abrogated (نَسْخ) by making fasting the sole requirement, while its recitation remained. Likewise, 'A bequest for parents and close relatives' is abrogated by his saying, peace be upon him, 'No bequest for an heir.' This requires examination (نَظَر), however, because some do not permit the Qurʾān to be abrogated by the Sunna (سُنَّة).

As for abrogating recitation while retaining the ruling (حُكْم), reports (خَبَر) corroborate one another that the recitation of the stoning verse was abrogated (نَسْخ) while its ruling remained. Yet this, too, requires examination (نَظَر) in my view: it should not be accepted that such wording was once part of the Qurʾān until it is established by mass transmission, and this should not be accepted through solitary routes.

[122] Question. Consensus (الإجماع) does not abrogate, because there is no abrogation after revelation has ceased. If something is supposed to have been abrogated by consensus, that consensus is evidence (دَلِيل) of an earlier abrogating (نَسْخ) text that has not reached us.

[123] Question. There is no disagreement over abrogating a Sunna established by mass transmission through another such Sunna (سُنَّة), solitary reports (خَبَر) through solitary reports, or solitary reports through mass transmission. Opinions differ about abrogating (نَسْخ) what is established by mass transmission through solitary reports. The preferred position is that this is rationally possible and occurred in the Law during the Prophet's lifetime, God bless him and grant him peace: the people of the mosque at Qubāʾ turned toward the Kaʿba on a solitary report (خَبَر الْوَاحِد), although their facing Jerusalem had been established by a decisive route. In general, the Messenger of God's sending emissaries to the outlying regions with abrogating and abrogated rulings, God bless him and grant him peace, is itself established by mass transmission (تَوَاتُر).

Its occurrence after his death, God bless him and grant him peace, is excluded by the Companions' consensus (إِجْمَاع) that the Qurʾān—and, in general, what is established by mass transmission (تَوَاتُر)—is not set aside by a solitary report (خَبَر الْوَاحِد). The reason seems to be indications accompanying reports (خَبَر) from the Messenger of God during his lifetime, God bless him and grant him peace, which do not accompany reports from him after his death, God bless him and grant him peace: the possibility (إِمْكَان) of going back to him, questioning him, and the like.

[124] As for abrogating the mass-transmitted (نَقْل) Qurʾān through a mass-transmitted (مُتَوَاتِر) Sunna, it is reported that al-Shāfiʿī and some Ẓāhirīs did

not permit this, on the evidence (دَلِيل) of God's saying, mighty and majestic, 'Whatever verse We abrogate or cause to be forgotten, We bring one better than it or like it.' Although the apparent meaning (ظَاهِر) of this verse supports their view, we have already said that the new verse may contain no replacement for the abrogated (نَسْخ) verse's ruling (حُكْم), while the Sunna (سُنَّة) supplies the replacement for that ruling.

Those who permit this invoke the abrogation (نَسْخ) of God's saying, 'A bequest for parents and close relatives,' by the Prophet's saying, peace be upon him, 'No bequest for an heir.' They also invoke his saying, peace be upon him, 'God has now appointed a way for them: for the never-married with the never-married, a hundred lashes and a year's banishment; and for the previously married with the previously married, a hundred lashes and stoning.' This abrogates 'Confine them in the houses.' These arguments admit possible alternative interpretations and are not decisive.

[125] Besides the argument already mentioned, what seems to have led those holding this position to exclude such abrogation (نَسْخ) is the greater weight we find them giving to the assent (التصديق) produced by the Book's mass transmission (نَقْل): this is the highest degree of mass transmission (تَوَاتُر). As for other reports, even when mass-transmitted, assent to them may fall short of assent to the Book. Contrary to what many think, it is not impossible for certain assent to admit degrees, especially where it rests on transmission. As for the report that al-Shāfiʿī, God have mercy on him, did not permit a mass-transmitted Sunna (سُنَّة) to be abrogated by the Qurʾān, this has no intelligible basis if taken in its apparent sense (مَعْنَى)—unless it is interpreted otherwise, for the possibilities of interpretation (تَأْوِيل) are ample.

[126] Question. A decisive, mass-transmitted text may not be abrogated by probable analogy, just as it may not be abrogated by a solitary report (خَبَر الْوَاحِد). Those who permit this argue from the permissibility of restricting the scope of a mass-transmitted (مُتَوَاتِر) text (نَصّ) through analogy (قِيَاس). Even if conceded, this is no proof (حُجَّة): specification (تَخْصِيص) clarifies, whereas abrogation (نَسْخ) removes.

The proof (حُجَّة) here is the Companions' consensus (إِجْمَاع) invalidating every opinion contrary to a text, all the more a mass-transmitted (مُتَوَاتِر) text; and the report of Muʿādh, when he said, 'I exercise my judgement' in the absence of a text (نَصّ), and the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, commended him for it. If two decisive texts contradict one another and the matter is unclear, may a solitary report (خَبَر) determine that one is later? This requires examination (نَظَر); the question is open to independent judgement.

[127] Question. A ruling (حُكْم) is not abrogated by a Companion's saying, 'Such-and-such a ruling was abrogated,' unless he says, 'I heard the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, say this.' That applies when the ruling was established by a solitary report (خَبَر الْوَاحِد), because what is not abrogation is often thought to be abrogation, as some have regarded an addition (زِيَادَة) to a text (نَصّ) as abrogation (نَسْخ). If the ruling was established through mass transmission (تَوَاتُر), a Companion's statement does not abrogate it even if he transmits the Messenger of God's own words, God bless him and grant him peace, since solitary transmission (نَقْل) does not abrogate mass transmission, as explained earlier.

[128] In general, you should know that abrogation has conditions contained implicitly in the definition (حَدّ) given earlier. First, what is removed must be a revealed ruling, not a rational judgement such as original freedom from liability (البراءة الأصلية), which is removed by the prescription of acts of worship (عِبَادَة). Second, abrogation must take place through discourse (خِطَاب), rather than the discourse whose ruling is removed being limited by a time whose arrival itself entails this. In general, according to each of the definitions of abrogation (نَسْخ) we have enumerated, some conditions apply and must be considered, while others fall outside it.

[129] Question. If two decisive texts conflict (تَعَارُض) and it is unknown which abrogates the other, this can be established only by transmission (نَقْل). There are several possible routes. First, the wording (لَفْظ) of one may indicate the abrogation of the other, as in his saying, peace be upon him, 'I used to forbid you such-and-such; now do it.' Second, their respective dates may be known. This

may also be known through the community's consensus that one of them has been abrogated (نَسْخ). Other circumstances thought to establish abrogation do not do so, such as a transmitter's later conversion to Islam, his younger age, or the ending of his companionship with the Prophet.

This concludes the discussion of the abrogating and the abrogated.

On the Third Source of Proofs: Consensus

[130] Consensus (الإجماع) is the agreement of the practitioners of independent judgement (حُكْم) within Muḥammad's community, God bless him and grant him peace, on a revealed ruling. This applies whether the bearer of the Law (شَرْع), God bless him and grant him peace, expressly stated the ruling but it was lost and not transmitted (نَقْل), or did not expressly state it, and they reached agreement through a contextual indication (قَرِينَة), a proof (دَلِيل), or something else producing agreement. Consensus adds nothing to the authentication of what the Prophet, peace be upon him, expressly stated and which was transmitted by mass transmission (تَوَاتُر). What was transmitted through solitary routes, however, consensus raises from the level of probability (ظَنّ) to that of certainty.

Where a ruling was not expressly stated, or was expressly stated but has not reached us, consensus (إِجْمَاع) is used as a decisive proof establishing it. Such consensus has in fact occurred in the Law. We can learn of it in one of two ways: if those agreeing are our contemporaries, by meeting them; if they belong to earlier generations, through widespread transmission (نَقْل) that produces assent (التصديق).

[131] The proof (دَلِيل) that consensus is authoritative is drawn from transmitted (نَقْل) revelation, the Book and the Sunna (سُنَّة). Among its texts is God's saying, 'Whoever opposes the Messenger after guidance has become clear to him and follows a way other than that of the believers, We shall turn him toward what he has chosen,' and the remainder of the verse. This is the strongest verse supporting reliance on consensus (إِجْمَاع). There are also His sayings, blessed and exalted: 'Thus We made you a community of the middle, so that you may be witnesses over humankind and the Messenger a witness over you'; 'You are the best community brought forth for humankind'; and 'Among those We have created is a community that guides by truth and acts justly by it.'

Although none of these verses taken separately is unambiguous wording (نص) establishing consensus (إِجْمَاع) as a revealed proof, together they require this community to be esteemed and honored, its way followed and agreement maintained with it, and they forbid opposing it and departing from its congregation.

In general, when these verses are joined to the transmitted reports affirming that this community is protected from error—reports mass-transmitted in meaning (مَعْنَى) even if not in wording (لَفْظ)—consensus (إِجْمَاع) is established with certainty as a revealed proof. Such reports (خَبَر) include his saying, peace be upon him: 'My community does not agree upon error (خَطَأ)'; his saying, peace be upon him, 'God would not bring my community into agreement upon error; whoever delights in the spacious heart of Paradise should keep to the congregation'; and his saying, peace be upon him, 'God's hand is with the congregation,' together with the other reports of this kind.

[132] An argument (دَلِيل) establishing the authority of consensus through reason (عَقْل) is weak. Although it is unlikely that many people would agree upon a lie, their agreeing upon an error is not unlikely. Indeed, we say that if only two or three practitioners of independent judgement remained and agreed on an opinion, consensus (إِجْمَاع) would be established through them, because the Law (شَرْع) attests their protection from error (خَطَأ) insofar as the name 'community' applies to them at that time.

[133] We specified practitioners of independent judgement in its definition because, although ordinary people can be conceived as participating in consensus (إِجْمَاع), this is only in matters transmitted (نَقْل) by mass transmission (تَوَاتُر), such as the five prayers, fasting, and almsgiving, or in matters in which they are included as followers of the consensus of those practitioners. Their agreement therefore adds nothing to establishing the correctness of anything. Ordinary people always follow practitioners of independent judgement and agree with them, since this is their duty. There is no objection to calling this consensus, but such consensus is not a source

(أَصْل) used by a practitioner of independent judgement.

134 As for the number of those agreeing, there is no condition (شَرْط) except that they comprise all qualified practitioners of independent judgement existing in a single age. If we required the agreement (إِجْمَاع) of people of every age—past, present, and future—no consensus could occur.

135 If the people of our age agree on something about which their predecessors did not agree, is consensus established? This requires examination (نَظَر). If the preceding generation was silent and no opinion on the matter has been transmitted from it, the consensus (إِجْمَاع) of later generations is necessarily established. Discussion arises when a disagreement has been transmitted (نَقْل) from the predecessors. Opinions differ, and the question is determined through the verbal forms (صِيغَة) of the statements affirming this community's protection from error, such as his saying, peace be upon him, 'My community will not agree upon misguidance,' and the other reports we have cited.

Although these cannot be understood with unrestricted generality, since the term 'community' cannot here include those yet to come, the term remains authoritative with respect to the generality of what remains within its scope. On what grounds, I wonder, can the preceding generation be excluded from the requirements of consensus (إِجْمَاع), when the remaining general scope (عُمُوم) of the expression (لَفْظ) includes them? This is possible only for someone who holds that a general expression (العام), once specified, is no longer authoritative for the generality of what remains.

136 This disagreement cannot arise for the Ẓāhirīs, because they consider consensus to be solely the Companions' agreement (إِجْمَاع) on a ruling (حُكْم), may God be pleased with them. This follows necessarily from their principles, since they do not allow consensus based on analogy. On their view, consensus therefore arises either from a report that has disappeared and has not reached us, or from indications and circumstances witnessed in the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace. Such a basis is conceivable only among the Companions. Those who permit consensus to arise from analogy (قِيَاس) must, however, confront the disagreement just mentioned. We shall explain this in the book on inference, when the meaning (مَعْنَى) they intend by analogy in this discipline (صِنَاعَة) has become clear.

137 Does the term 'community' also include every individual practitioner of independent judgement in that age, so that a single dissenter prevents consensus (إِجْمَاع), or does it mean the majority? The apparent (ظَاهِر) sense of the transmitted (نَقْل) formulas includes them all. In general, examination (نَظَر) of these conditions of consensus seems to be a matter for independent judgement. There is also disagreement when an opinion is transmitted from most of them and the rest are silent. The more evident view, as al-Shāfiʿī says, is that a speaker's position should not be attributed to someone silent—unless the silent persons' circumstances indicate that their silence may have expressed approval of, and agreement with, that opinion.

A person may remain silent for many reasons: he may have no opinion on the matter at that time; or, if he has an opinion, obstacles may prevent him from stating it. He may think that the ruling is open to independent judgement (حُكْم), or that every practitioner of independent judgement is correct; he may be inhibited by awe, or by other accompanying circumstances.

138 Since this is so, and consensus requires agreement (إِجْمَاع) among all practitioners of independent judgement existing in the age, there is no basis for treating the agreement of the people of Medina as authoritative because they were the majority at the beginning of Islam.

The discerning Mālikīs, however, regard it as authoritative on the ground of transmission. If an argument (حُجَّة) for its authority is to be built on this, it seems to me that the transmission (نَقْل) of the practice must be explicitly stated, generation after generation, until it reaches the Messenger of God's time, God bless him and grant him peace. It would then be authoritative through his approval, God bless him and grant him peace. For example, they would say, 'This is how we found our fathers acting,' tracing this back to the Messenger of God's time, God bless him and grant him peace.

Such was the encounter between Mālik and Abū Yūsuf in al-Rashīd's presence concerning the ṣāʿ measure. If this requirement is neither imposed nor carefully maintained, their agreement may concern a practice forced upon them by some

caliph or governor. In general, it is clear that reaching a legal judgement (حُكْم) on this basis does not refer back to a source (أَصْل) established with certainty in the Law (شَرْع), as a probable indication ought to do—unless transmission (نَقْل) of the practice is explicitly stated as we have described, in which case it belongs to transmitted evidence.

[139] The requirement that the generation of practitioners of independent judgement must die out without disagreement intervening is not entailed by the wording of the reports establishing the authority of consensus (إِجْمَاع). Rather, anyone who dissents after consensus has existed for even a single moment is disregarded and is certainly in error.

[140] This is our account, as concise as we could make it, of what consensus is and of its requirements. Someone who has grasped consensus (إِجْمَاع) to the extent set out here can readily understand the further questions and objections connected with it, which Abū Ḥāmid has discussed at such length.

On the Fourth Source

[141] This is rational evidence (دَلِيل) for presuming the continuation (الاستصحاب) of freedom from obligations and the absence of blame for people where no command or prohibition (نَهْي) has been received: for example, the absence of an obligation to perform a sixth prayer, eating during Shawwāl, and the like. In general, calling this a proof is a loose use of language. They were led to it by straining to make revealed matters require proof for both negation and affirmation, just as rational matters do. Thus you see them wavering: sometimes they say, 'The absence of proof is proof'; sometimes, 'It is established by analogy (قِيَاس) or consensus (إِجْمَاع) that anything for which no proof is found in the Law (شَرْع) original freedom from liability is presumed to continue.'

The correct view is otherwise. Anything whose existence can be established only by revelation is presumed absent until something to the contrary is received; its absence is the better-known state. In such a case, either no proof (دَلِيل) at all should be demanded from people, or, if proof is demanded, it should be less than that demanded from someone affirming its existence, as with a claimant and a defendant.

[142] Presumption of continuity (الاستصحاب) has several applications in this discipline (صِنَاعَة). First is the continuation of original freedom from liability (البراءة الأصلية), discussed earlier. Second is retaining general scope (عُمُوم) until a specification (تَخْصِيص) is received. Third is retaining the text (نَصّ) until abrogation (نَسْخ) is received. Fourth is retaining a ruling (حُكْم) when the circumstance to which the Law (شَرْع) attached it recurs. Fifth is retaining consensus (إِجْمَاع)—or, more generally, a revealed ruling established by transmission (نَقْل)—in a case where the subject's ruling is thought to have changed because the subject itself has changed, as with selling a slave woman who has borne her master a child, and similar cases.

The Ẓāhirīs accept this presumption of continuity (اسْتِصْحَاب) and thereby remain consistent with their principles. Those who do not allow in the Law (شَرْع) the kind of reasoning called analogy (قِيَاس) by practitioners of this discipline (صِنَاعَة) hold that things remain in their original freedom from liability until revealed evidence (دَلِيل) is received. Similarly, once revealed evidence is received, the subject retains its ruling even if its attributes change, until evidence removing the ruling is received.

It is as though the situation here were the reverse of presuming original freedom from liability. There, absence was more evident, so proof (دَلِيل) was required from whoever affirmed; here, existence is more evident, so proof is required from whoever denies. Someone who accepts analogy in the Law (شَرْع) must reject this kind of continuity (اسْتِصْحَاب), since he can say: we are charged to reason by analogy (قِيَاس) where there is no text (نَصّ). This subject's attribute has changed, so it has the status of a case for which no text has been received, because a change of attribute requires a change of ruling (حُكْم).

[143] Here the discussion of the fourth source (أَصْل) ends, and with it the discussion of the second part of this book, which comprises the sources of proofs.

[144] Other sources may be supposed to exist, and we shall mention them. One is a Companion's statement, which is thought authoritative but is not. One may not follow uncritically someone whose protection from error has not been

established; such protection is established only by a miracle, or by the bearer of a miracle declaring that the person is protected from error. Opinions differ: some confine this authority to particular Companions; others extend it to every Companion. In general, a Companion is one practitioner of independent judgement among others. The mind nevertheless inclines more readily to their opinions because of the indications accompanying them, and these indications led those who regard their statements as authoritative to that view.

145 Another is the law of those before us. The proof that this is not a source (أَصْل) is that, were it a source, transmitting it would be a collective obligation. It cannot be right that the community should, at any time, lose knowledge of a collective obligation, given the proof (دَلِيل) of its protection from error. Had its transmission been a collective obligation (فَرْض), the Companions would have reported it and it would have been transmitted (نَقْل) down to the present. As for provisions of earlier laws contained in the Book and commanded of us, they are commanded of us insofar as they are in the Book, not insofar as they are the law (شَرْع) of those before us.

146 Others are juristic preference (اسْتِحْسَان) and consideration of welfare (اسْتِصْلَاح). If these mean a kind of analogy, evident or subtle, permissible in the Law in the manner allowed by its proponents, then it is a source (أَصْل) on their view. If they do not mean that, they are not a source. In general, the Law (شَرْع) has encouraged consideration (نَظَر) of benefits, but to a certain extent and within a certain limit (حَدّ): where it has attested that they, or their kind, constitute a benefit (مَصْلَحَة). Whether analogy (قِيَاس) itself is a source will be discussed later.

147 Here the examination (نَظَر) of the second part of this science (عِلْم) ends. Praise be to God.

Part III · Derivation

On the Third Part of the Abridgment

148 This part concerns the inquiry (نَظَر) most distinctive of this science (عِلْم), as we explained earlier. It is divided according to the things through which the Prophet's meaning is understood, God bless him and grant him peace: either wording (لَفْظ) or an indication (قرينة).

149 Wording is divided into what indicates a ruling (حُكْم) through its verbal form (لَفْظ), and what indicates it through its understood import and intelligible meaning.

150 Indication is divided into two kinds: one is his action, God bless him and grant him peace; the other is his approval of a ruling (حُكْم).

1. On Unambiguous and Indeterminate Wording in Respect of Verbal Form

151 Let us begin by examining wording. We say: practitioners of this discipline (صِنَاعَة) customarily divide expressions and statements into the indeterminate (المجمل), the unambiguous (النص), what has an apparent meaning (مَعْنَى) (الظاهر), and what is interpreted beyond that apparent meaning (المؤول). We should examine each division and explain what they signify by each. We say:

152 Expressions are either simple or compound. A simple expression is a noun, a verb, or a particle. A compound expression is composed of these, with a part of it signifying part of its meaning (مَعْنَى). Some compound expressions do not independently convey a complete meaning; others do. The latter divide into statements whose composition admits truth or falsehood, and ⟨utterances which do not⟩. The latter include commands, prohibitions, requests, entreaties, and calls.

153 Among expressions—whether nouns, particles, or verbs, simple or compound—some invariably convey one meaning (مَعْنَى) through their forms in every context (قَرِينَة). These constitute part of what is meant by unambiguous wording (لَفْظ) (النص) in this discipline; let us call it unambiguous wording in respect of form. Others can convey more than one meaning. If they signify all these meanings equally, so that one can be understood only through proof or an indication (دَلِيل), they constitute part of what this discipline (صِنَاعَة) calls indeterminate wording (المجمل); let us call it indeterminate wording in respect of form (صِيغَة).

Some expressions originally apply to one thing and signify it more commonly, but are later transferred to something else because it resembles the original meaning (مَعْنَى); or one expression is substituted for another, relying on an indication (دَلَالَة) to disclose the transferred or substituted meaning. When such expressions occur without accompanying indications, they are understood

according to their original assignment. These constitute part of what this discipline calls apparent wording (الظاهر); following our practice, let us call it apparent wording in respect of form (صِيغَة). When indications establish transfer or substitution, this constitutes part of what the discipline (صِنَاعَة) calls interpreted wording (المؤول); let us call it interpreted wording in respect of form.

This class includes terms established by specialised usage: terms originally assigned to certain things, then transferred in the Law (شَرْع) to other things because of their resemblance to the original meanings or some relation to them. When these occur in the Law, their apparent meanings are the legal meanings; they are understood in their ordinary linguistic meanings only through interpretation (تَأْوِيل).

[154] Some expressions and statements signify through their understood imports, rather than through their verbal forms, because they have been altered by abridgement and omission or addition (زِيَادَة), and likewise by substitution (إِبْدَال) and transfer (اسْتِعَارَة). This class of expressions is called figurative usage (مجاز).

[155] Within these, too, there are counterparts to the unambiguous, the indeterminate (مُجْمَل), the apparent, and the interpreted (مُؤَوَّل); but they possess these characteristics through accompanying indications, not through their forms. Thus 'unambiguous (نَصّ) wording' as used in this discipline (صِنَاعَة) signifies two kinds: what is unambiguous in respect of form (صِيغَة) and what is unambiguous in respect of understood import (مَفْهُوم). The apparent (ظَاهِر), the indeterminate, and the interpreted admit the same division.

[156] This division of expressions into these classes seems to be the useful one in this discipline (صِنَاعَة). We should examine them following the practitioners' customary procedure, explain the authority of each as a revealed proof, and investigate statements thought to be uncertain between more than one of these classes. Let us begin with the divisions belonging to an expression (لَفْظ) by virtue of its form, and among these with simple expressions and expressions compounded as assertions.

[157] As we have said, wording (لَفْظ) is unambiguous only when it conveys one meaning (مَعْنَى) in every context. This occurs in both simple and compound expressions. Examples of simple expressions are 'human being,' 'horse,' and 'animal.' A compound example (مِثَال) is God's saying, 'Say: He is God, One.' In general, this includes every expression composed of unambiguous (نَصّ) simple expressions, provided that its pronouns cannot refer to more than one meaning.

[158] Indeterminate wording (مُجْمَل) in respect of form (صِيغَة) is the opposite. Among simple expressions, an example is ʿayn, used equivocally for a spring of water, the eye of a balance, the eye with which one sees, and other things. A term may even signify a thing and its opposite, as qurʾ (قُرْء) sometimes means a period of purity and sometimes menstruation. Indeterminacy in composition occurs in expressions compounded from such terms, or where the pronouns connecting the statement are ambiguous. An example is His saying, blessed and exalted, 'Or the one in whose hand is the marriage bond remits it': the pronoun (ضَمِير) here may refer either to the guardian or to the husband.

[159] In this discipline (صِنَاعَة) they apply the term 'clarification (بَيَان)' to everything through which rulings may be established and understanding produced: an expression (لَفْظ)'s form (صِيغَة), its understood import, and the other things enumerated earlier, according to their degrees in producing assent (التصديق). We shall discuss the authority of each as a revealed proof.

[160] Indeterminate wording is not clarification (بَيَان), by consensus (إِجْمَاع), and establishes no ruling (حُكْم) at all. A question arises here: may an instruction be addressed through indeterminate wording (مُجْمَل) pending clarification, or through apparent (ظَاهِر) wording pending specification (تَخْصِيص), at the time when clarification is needed? This is the question they designate as the permissibility of delaying clarification beyond the time of need. Some permit it, while others forbid it. Our account is as follows.

[161] Inquiry into this question is linguistic, so we should examine it from the standpoint appropriate to language. Surveying Arabic speech (كَلَام) shows that Arabs address others with an equivocal term

only where evidence (دَلِيل) indicates the intended meaning (مَقْصُود) from among its other meanings, whether through a readily available contextual indication (قَرِينَة) or something present in the wording (لَفْظ) itself. In God's saying, blessed and exalted, 'Then it became like al-ṣarīm,' preceding descriptions of the thing compared indicate that al-ṣarīm here means night. Similarly, when they mean morning by al-ṣarīm, they say 'the light of al-ṣarīm,' or something comparable.

In general, addressing someone with indeterminate expressions while knowing with certainty that they remain indeterminate has never occurred; if it did, it would be idle speech. A speaker may, however, use an indeterminate (مُجْمَل) term believing it very likely that he will be understood, relying on accompanying indications, while the addressee fails to understand him. The addressee may then seek clarification (بَيَان), and the speaker provide it. If the addressee sees that fulfilment of what he was addressed with is not required at that moment, he postpones his question until the time of need, and clarification is correspondingly delayed.

But for a speaker to address (خِطَاب) someone in indeterminate expressions, knowing with certainty that they are indeterminate and that the addressee understands nothing by them, while relying on explaining the intended meaning (مَقْصُود) when the time of need arrives—this, as we have said, has never occurred among Arabs or anyone else. In general, such indeterminate address occurs only when a riddle or mockery of the addressee's disposition is intended. The same holds of wording indeterminate in its understood import. The Law (شَرْع) has introduced no specialised convention altering this.

[162] Apparent wording (لَفْظ) in respect of form (صِيغَة) also has, in my view, the same status as an equivocal term. This concerns what originally applies to something and has its apparent meaning (ظَاهِر) in it, but is later transferred to another thing because of resemblance to the first meaning (مَعْنَى) or some relation to it. When an Arab uses the word 'sky' without qualification, he is invariably understood to mean the starry sky. If he means rain, he indicates this through a contextual clue (قَرِينَة), as in 'We kept treading the sky until we reached you,' or 'When the sky falls upon a people's land.'

Otherwise, whenever such terms are used without qualification while something other than their established meaning is intended, this can occur only as an error; if deliberate, it is misleading. This concerns the time of need. If it is not yet the time of need, what benefit is there in speech that makes a person believe the opposite of what the subsequent clarification (بَيَان) will convey? Apparent (ظَاهِر) wording in respect of understood import (مَفْهُوم) seems to stand on the same footing.

[163] As for apparent (ظَاهِر) wording involving substitution (الإبدال)—general expressions by which something falling under them is intended—addressing people with these expressions without qualification or an accompanying indication identifying the specific meaning (مَعْنَى) intended, deliberately postponing clarification (بَيَان) until the time of need, does occur in language and in the Law. This is so when the addressees understand from contextual indications that there remains a question to ask, and that the speaker did not intend to confine himself to what he has already said.

God's saying, mighty and majestic, 'God commands you to slaughter a cow,' was of this kind (جِنْس). They kept asking, and the answers supplied specifications until the particular cow was identified for them. If the addressees do not know from contextual indications that there is a question to ask, this does not occur. It is permissible with general wording (عَامّ), but not with indeterminate wording (مُجْمَل) or the first kind of apparent (ظَاهِر) wording, because someone who knows a thing through a universal description (كلي) knows it in some respect, while awaiting a more specific knowledge of it.

Statements composed of such descriptions are often clearer than names, or indispensable for things that have no names, as with the cow they were commanded to slaughter. On this basis, terms established by specialised usage may be used before the meanings signified by them are understood, relying on the addressees' knowledge that those terms signify meanings additional to their original assignment (وَضْع). The benefit is to produce resolve to obey the command even while its detailed clarification (بَيَان) is deferred until the

time of need—as with commanding almsgiving and pilgrimage before they become obligatory.

If you examine the cases cited by those who permit delaying clarification (بَيَان) until the time of need without distinguishing among cases, you will find them included in the classes we have enumerated. Likewise, if you examine the evidence cited by those who [do not] permit it, you will find that it concerns wholly indeterminate wording (مُجْمَل) admitting alternatives, and the first kind of apparent (ظَاهِر) wording. In general, both positions, taken without qualification, are partly false, as positions supported by an induction (اسْتِقْرَاء) that does not exhaust all particulars are liable to be false. That clarification may not be delayed beyond the time of need, however, is undisputed.

Having discussed indeterminate (مُجْمَل) and unambiguous (نَصّ) wording, let us turn to apparent (ظَاهِر) and interpreted wording (مُؤَوَّل).

2. On Apparent and Interpreted Wording in Respect of Verbal Form

[164] As we have said, apparent (ظَاهِر) wording in respect of form (صِيغَة) is of two kinds. The first comprises expressions originally applied to one thing, then transferred to another because of resemblance or some relation between them. Transfer through resemblance is exemplified by calling a bed a 'nest'; transfer through another relation, by calling vegetation 'dew,' because it arises from dew. This class includes indirect expression (كِنَايَة), such as referring to excrement as 'the low ground' and sexual intercourse as 'touching.'

[165] The second class of apparent expressions consists of substituted expressions. By substitution here we mean placing the universal (الكلي) in place of the particular (الجزئي), or the particular in place of the universal. Strictly speaking, substitution applies to all transferred expressions, which are then divided into the classes we have enumerated. We have nevertheless chosen to reserve the name 'substitution' (التبديل) for this class, namely the universal and the particular, although in reality everything substituted is transferred, and everything transferred is substituted.

[166] When these two classes occur without qualification in the Law, they are understood in their apparent meanings until evidence (دَلِيل) indicates otherwise—that is, indicates that they should be understood in a transferred meaning (مَعْنَى), which is what is called interpretation (تأويل). That these expressions have these apparent significations is known necessarily through a survey of language. Their authority as revealed proof is known through the Companions' consensus (إِجْمَاع) on adopting apparent meanings and through the fact that the Law (شَرْع) has introduced no specialised convention altering this.

Moreover, if we did not adopt apparent meanings, many acts of worship (عِبَادَة) would lapse, because unambiguous texts (النصوص) are extremely scarce. The necessity (ضَرُورَة) calling for action upon solitary reports (خَبَر) is here the necessity calling for action upon the apparent meanings of expressions. These expressions admit degrees of apparentness: the stronger an expression (لَفْظ)'s apparent meaning, the stronger the evidence (دَلِيل) required to interpret it otherwise; conversely, the weaker its apparent meaning (ظَاهِر), the slighter the evidence sufficient for interpretation (تَأْوِيل). Let us give three examples, one at the first degree, a second at the intermediate degree, and a third at the last degree, for both classes of apparent wording.

[167] At the first degree among transferred terms is the interpretation of God's saying, mighty and majestic, 'Children of Adam, We have sent down upon you clothing to cover your nakedness,' as meaning rain by 'clothing.' Such an interpretation (تَأْوِيل) requires evidence (دَلِيل), since 'clothing' very strongly signifies what covers a person. The second degree is exemplified by interpreting God's saying, 'We sent Our messengers with clear proofs and sent down with them the Book and the balance,' as meaning justice by 'the balance.'

The third degree is exemplified by God's saying, 'Or you have touched women.' Some jurists understand this as touching with the hand; others as sexual intercourse. Although its apparent meaning (ظَاهِر) is touching with the hand, it can quite plausibly mean intercourse, since this accords with Arab usage, and God Most High has referred indirectly to intercourse by massīs, which has the meaning (مَعْنَى) of touching.

[168] In general, degrees of apparentness in expressions depend on frequency or rarity of use.

If use in the transferred meaning becomes as frequent as use in the original meaning, the expression (لَفْظ) stands equivocally between the first and second meanings and is indeterminate. The less frequently it is used in the second meaning (مَعْنَى), the more apparent it is in the first.

Interpretation (تَأْوِيل) of apparent (ظَاهِر) wording may be self-evident or may require an explanation; it may amount to predominant probability or to certainty. A self-evident and certain (قَطْعِيّ) example (مِثَال) is their saying, 'We kept treading the sky until we reached you.' An example made clear by decisive proof (دَلِيل) is God's saying, 'The All-Merciful is established over the Throne': decisive proof has established that 'being established' here is not occupying a place.

169 The second class of apparent wording, which we called substituted wording, also has two kinds: universal wording (الكلي) and particular wording (الجزئي). Let us first examine the universal, which is the general (العام). General wording (لَفْظ) has many forms. Some dispute that expressions signify generality (عُمُوم) and that, when unqualified, they apparently encompass everything falling under them. Their objection has no basis: the matter is evident, and indeed shared by all tongues and languages. The Law (شَرْع) has introduced no specialised convention changing it. The argument (حُجَّة) establishing its authority as revealed proof is the argument establishing the authority of apparent (ظَاهِر) wording as such, which has already been given.

170 These expressions have many forms. They include plural nouns, with or without the definite article; names of genera, species, and classes when they have the definite article and do not end in the feminine ending, [although the received examples 'the fruit,' 'the date palm,' and 'the woman' themselves carry that ending]; man and mā ('whoever' and 'whatever') when used ⟨in conditional and consequential clauses⟩, together with ayna and matā ('wherever' and 'whenever'); negative particles; and emphatic expressions such as 'all of them' and 'every one.'

When these forms are used without qualification, they are generally understood in their full generality until evidence (دَلِيل) establishes a specification. They, too, admit degrees of apparentness, as did the first class. Their interpretive proofs have corresponding degrees, because evidence for interpretation must always signify more strongly than the expression (لَفْظ)'s form (صِيغَة). Examples at the respective degrees follow.

171 At the first degree of apparentness is his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, 'Any woman who marries without her guardian's permission (إِذْن), her marriage is invalid (بَاطِل).' Some apply this to a slave woman. When that proved untenable because of his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, 'She is entitled to the dower'—whereas a slave woman's dower belongs to her master—they applied it to a slave woman under a contract for emancipation. This is a remote interpretation (تَأْوِيل).

172 The second degree is his saying, peace be upon him, 'There is no fasting for someone who has not resolved upon the fast during the night.' Some apply this to a fast making up (قَضَاء) a missed obligation and to a vowed fast. This interpretation (تَأْوِيل) is closer than the first.

173 The third degree is his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, 'On what the sky waters, a tenth; on what is irrigated by drawing water, half a tenth.' Some apply this to everything, even taking almsgiving from vegetables. Others say that it is confined to the various grains from which almsgiving is taken.

174 These are the kinds of general expressions and their degrees of apparentness. Sometimes general wording (لَفْظ) (العام) occurs with a specific meaning (الخاص) intended, and this is clear from the outset —as when someone beating his child says, 'There is no good in children.' This understanding may be predominantly probable or certain (قَطْعِيّ), according to the particular indication (دَلِيل). It may also become clear through proof, which itself may be decisive or predominantly probable. Sometimes we know that general wording is intended specifically without knowing which specific meaning is intended; its force may then be that of indeterminate wording (المجمل).

175 It remains to discuss kinds of expressions thought to have general scope (عُمُوم) when they do not, or thought not to have general scope when they do. We shall set out several questions on this.

176 Question. Generality (عَامّ) in wording (لَفْظ) occurs when the Lawgiver uses it in an

independent statement, or in reply to a question arising from a specific (خَاصّ) circumstance but frames the answer generally. For example, when asked about the well of Buḍāʿa, he said, God bless him and grant him peace, 'God created water as purifying; nothing renders it impure.' This statement is understood to concern all water, not only that well. Some regard such a statement as specific and confine it to the thing asked about, even when it is framed generally. Their position has no basis, for the matter is clear.

177 Question. An equivocal term does not have general scope (عُمُوم) encompassing everything to which it applies. Some hold otherwise, as do those who understand 'Or you have touched women' to cover both intercourse and touching with the bodily member, the hand. A survey of Arabic speech (كَلَام) shows the contrary: Arabs do not use the term ʿayn, for example, intending their hearer to understand all the meanings to which it applies. This is clearest in terms used for opposites. Someone might claim that such an inclusive meaning (مَعْنَى) is understood through a specialised legal convention (عُرْف), but anyone making that claim must establish it.

178 Question. The expressions 'people' and 'human being' include the slave, the unbeliever, the male, and the female. 'The believers' includes the slave but does not include women, since its form (صِيغَة) is specifically a masculine plural.

179 Question. General wording (لَفْظ) may be understood without exhaustive inclusion (عُمُوم). Abū Ḥāmid claims, however, that it cannot be reduced to less than the minimum denoted by a plural, on the view that the least number a plural denotes is two. This requires examination (نَظَر).

180 Question. A plural expression (لَفْظ), when unqualified, denotes at least three or more, and is more apparent in that sense than in the sense of two; it is understood as two only through an accompanying indication. It is remarkable that anyone should understand unqualified plural expressions as denoting two, when two has its own distinctive form (صِيغَة). That a plural may be used figuratively to mean two is not denied, but this is substitution (إِبْدَال) and extended usage, like what occurs with other expressions conventionally assigned to something. Examining the cases cited by those who permit this shows them to be of that kind.

Investigators in this field, however, customarily fail, when discussing verbal signification (دَلَالَة), to distinguish an expression (لَفْظ)'s established signification from what it signifies by extended use and transfer (اسْتِعَارَة). Thus we see them saying that a plural applies to two just as it applies to three or more. This is what has misled those investigating this question in this discipline (صِنَاعَة) when they appeal to Sībawayh and other grammarians, and to examples occurring in Arabic speech (كَلَام).

Nor is this alone found in their speech—I mean using a plural form (صِيغَة) to signify two. They may also use it to signify one, but do so by way of magnification, as when they say, 'He is all people,' or 'He is the young man, the whole of a young man.'

181 As explained earlier, these general (عَامّ) expressions may occur with a specific meaning intended. Sometimes this is clear from the outset; sometimes it is not and requires evidence (دَلِيل): wording, an action (فِعْل), an approval (إِقْرَار), or one of the other proofs used in this discipline (صِنَاعَة). Accordingly, when one seeks to specify general wording (لَفْظ) through any of these, one must consider which has the stronger rank in producing predominant probability (غَلَبَة الظَّنّ).

Opinions differ concerning the specification of general wording (عَامّ) through these other revealed proofs. Some hold that when a general statement concerning something is received together with a specification—whether through verbal form (لَفْظ), understood import (مَفْهُوم), action (فِعْل), or approval (إِقْرَار)—the two have the status of conflicting evidence (دَلِيل). The general statement may, for example, have come later than the specifying evidence, whether wording, action, or approval, and thus abrogate it, unless it is known that the specification (تَخْصِيص) followed the general statement as clarification (بَيَان) delayed until the time of need. This is the position of Dāwūd and his followers.

182 Those who permit specifying general wording (عَامّ) through such proofs without knowing their chronological order appeal to the Companions' practice of doing so and of making the specific (خَاصّ) govern the general. On this view, the general

and specific have one of two relations: either the general expression (لَفْظ) comes after the specific, which then serves as an indication (دَلِيل) specifying (تَخْصِيص) the general, since the wording admits this; or the specific comes after the general and is acted upon.

In general (عَامّ), as we have said, whoever permits specification through such proofs should follow whichever ranks highest in predominant probability (غَلَبَة الظَّنّ). This predominance may arise from the wording or from its transmission (نَقْل). Thus someone may permit specifying general wording through an unambiguous text (نَصّ), yet refuse this in the Qur'ān because the Qur'ān is established by mass transmission—when the specifying (تَخْصِيص) text is transmitted through solitary routes.

183 Exception (اِسْتِثْنَاء) is a kind of specification of general wording (عَامّ), but differs from specification (تَخْصِيص) in that it does not occur separately from the expression to which it belongs. There is therefore no basis for permitting an exception to be postponed. We should discuss this. The forms (صِيغَة) of exception are well known; the kinds that require examination here are the following.

184 An exception (اِسْتِثْنَاء) may be connected, where the thing excepted belongs to the same genus as that from which it is excepted; or disconnected, where it belongs to a different genus (جِنْس). Language specialists call the latter a discontinuous exception. An exception may also follow a single complete sentence, or several sentences. We shall examine both these divisions.

185 There is no disagreement over an exception belonging to the same genus as that from which it is excepted. Disagreement concerns an exception belonging to another genus (جِنْس). Some reject it, saying that there is no sense (مَعْنَى) in excepting (اِسْتِثْنَاء) what the preceding statement did not include, and that calling such a thing an exception is idle speech. Those who permit it appeal to its occurrence in language, as in God's sayings, 'For they are enemies to me, except the Lord of the worlds,' and 'Do not consume your wealth among yourselves wrongfully, except that it be an immediate transaction.'

A comparable instance is the poet's saying, 'No one is at the campsite except the horse tethering places.' The term 'anyone' does not apply to tethering places. Another poet says, 'And a land with no companion in it, except gazelles and except white camels.' Arabs also customarily say, 'There is no man in the house except a woman.' In general, this is well known and frequent in their speech.

The first group rejects it on theoretical grounds; the second appeals to its actual occurrence, but has been unable to explain how it is valid in speech (كَلَام) according to known Arab usage, and thereby resolve the difficulty raised earlier.

186 Our account is this: as explained earlier, Arabs customarily substitute the universal for the particular and the particular (جُزْئِيّ) for the universal (كُلِّيّ), relying on accompanying indications and extended usage. If a Bedouin says, for example, 'There is no man in the house,' his negation may be understood to extend beyond men; hence he adds the exception, 'except a woman.' The same holds of 'And a land with no companion in it.' On the account we have given, the thing excepted does not belong to a genus (جِنْس) different from that from which it is excepted.

The difference from the first kind is that the first excepts something from the general scope conveyed by the expression (لَفْظ)'s form, whereas this excepts it from the general scope (عُمُوم) conveyed by its understood import, not its form. If you examine the occurrences of such exceptions, you will find them to be as we have described; otherwise, the statement would be contradictory and idle, incapable of sustaining intelligible conversation.

187 If an exception follows several sentences joined by 'and,' and 'and' makes them share or combine in one meaning, the more evident reading is that the exception (اِسْتِثْنَاء) refers to everything mentioned. If 'and' joins them without making them share one meaning (مَعْنَى), and the joined meanings are multiple, the case is different. An example is God's saying, 'Those who accuse chaste women and then do not produce four witnesses: lash them eighty times, never accept their testimony, and they are the wrongdoers—except those who repent thereafter and make amends.'

Another example is His saying, ‘Its expiation is feeding ten needy people from the average of what you feed your families, or clothing them, or freeing a slave; whoever cannot find the means must fast three days.’ In such cases the more evident course is to suspend judgement until evidence (دَلِيل), whether a contextual indication (قَرِينَة) or something else, shows what the exception (اسْتِثْنَاء) refers to.

188 As for whether the amount remaining after an exception may be smaller than the amount excepted, this is something that has not occurred in Arabic speech (كَلَام), since such an expression would almost amount to an inability to express oneself. It is an incongruous way of speaking to say, ‘I saw a hundred, except ninety-nine.’

189 Question. When general wording (عَامّ) is qualified by an attribute or made conditional on something, there should be no disagreement about acting upon it subject to that condition (شَرْط). If it occurs unqualified in one context and then qualified (مُقَيَّد) in the same context—what they call construing the unqualified (مُطْلَق) in light of the qualified—the majority adopt that construction. An example is his saying, peace be upon him, ‘There is no marriage without two witnesses,’ alongside his saying, peace be upon him, ‘There is no marriage without two witnesses of probity.’

Some hold that the unqualified statement retains its unqualified scope, that the qualification serves to emphasize, and that it conflicts with the unqualified statement only through contrary implication (الخطاب دليل). Generality is stronger than contrary implication—I mean the generality (عُمُوم) present in the unqualified (مُطْلَق) statement. If, however, the general expression (عَامّ) is qualified in a context different from the one in which it was unqualified, there is no basis for construing it as qualified without proof or a contextual indication (قَرِينَة).

190 This is the account of general verbal forms (صِيغَة), and of the circumstances in which they are understood generally and those in which they are not. It remains to discuss the second class of apparent (ظَاهِر) wording, namely specific expressions. Let us turn to them.

3. On specific expressions

191 Some of these are names of individuals, and others are names of genera and species. When we call such expressions “specific” (خاص), we do so relatively: something is called specific in relation to the general term (عَامّ) above it, and general in relation to the specific term below it.

When these expressions name individuals, they are construed as bearing the specific meaning required by their forms, rather than a meaning encompassing that specific (خَاصّ) meaning (مَعْنَى). This is their prima facie import (ظاهر), just as expressions of generality prima facie retain their general scope (عُمُوم) until evidence (دَلِيل) of restriction (تَخْصِيص) appears. Similarly, names of genera and species prima facie encompass what falls under them, while delimiting the meanings their forms initially signify from anything more general, until evidence requires generalization. Here too there are degrees of prima facie clarity.

Just as speakers customarily substitute the general (عَامّ) universal for the specific particular, so here they customarily substitute the specific (خَاصّ) particular (جُزْئِيّ) for the general, relying on contextual indications (قرائن). This too may be evident in itself and certain, or it may rest on a preponderant probability, or it may not be evident in itself. Sometimes the occurrence of substitution (إِبْدَال) is itself evident, while it remains unclear which universal (كُلِّيّ) the particular has been substituted for.

An example evident in itself and certain is His exalted saying, “Do not say ‘Uff’ to the two of them,” and the Prophet’s saying, peace be upon him, “Hand over the thread and the needle.” Examples evident in themselves but not certain are the prohibition of entering the mosque smelling of garlic, and of drinking from silver vessels. An example (مِثَال) not evident in itself is his prohibition (نَهْي), peace be upon him, concerning wheat exchanged for wheat—the four commodities mentioned. Some understood it as referring to staple nourishment, others to food, and others to goods measured by volume; others confined the ruling (حُكْم) to the stated text (نَصّ).

192 This completes the discussion of indeterminate, unambiguous (نَصّ), prima facie, and interpreted expressions with respect to their forms. It remains

to discuss them with respect to their understood meaning (مفهوم).

4. On expressions signifying through their understood meaning

193 As we said before, an expression (لَفْظ) signifies through its understood meaning when some of its parts are omitted, something is added to it, or it is used metaphorically or by substitution. In such cases its signification comes only through contextual indications. If the contextual indication (قَرِينَة) is unvarying and decisive as to its understood meaning, the expression is again called unambiguous (نص). If it supplies a preponderant probability, it is called prima facie (ظاهر); if it supplies probability without preponderance, it is called indeterminate (مجمل), and evidence for it is sought elsewhere.

Examples involving metaphor and substitution have already been given. What remains for us here is the case in which this occurs through omission. We say:

194 An example (مِثَال) having the status of an unambiguous (نَصّ) expression is His exalted saying, “Ask the village in which we were.” It is known with certainty that He means the inhabitants of the village. Likewise, in His exalted saying, “Forbidden to you are your mothers,” what is certainly understood here is marriage.

An example in this class (جِنْس) resembling a prima facie expression is his saying, peace be upon him, “There is no fast for one who has not resolved upon the fast overnight.” This may mean that the fast is not complete, or that the fast is not accepted at all; the latter is more apparent (ظَاهِر). An example (مِثَال) thought indeterminate is his saying, peace be upon him, “Whoever has caught one cycle of the prayer has caught the prayer.” It is undecided whether this means obtaining the prayer’s merit, its legal effect, or its appointed time.

A particularly well-known kind within this class (جِنْس) is what they call inference from the discourse (دليل الخطاب). Something is mentioned subject to a qualification or condition, and a ruling (حُكْم) is attached to it. It is then judged probable that the ruling belongs to it insofar as it bears that qualification (شَرْط) or description, and that, when the description is absent, the ruling ceases to apply and its contradictory applies instead.

This class (جِنْس) has several kinds. They disagree over whether these constitute legal evidence (دَلِيل). Some have allowed none of them as evidence at all; some have allowed all of them; others have allowed some and denied others. We say concerning this:

195 Its kinds include mentioning something qualified by a description, as in his saying, peace be upon him, “Zakāt is due on grazing sheep.” Another is to make something conditional through one of the conditional particles, as in “Whoever enters the house, give him a dirham.” This, in their view, occupies a stronger rank.

Another restricts a ruling (حُكْم) through a restrictive particle: innamā or the definite article al-, as in his saying, peace be upon him, “The rights of clientage belong only to the emancipator,” or in “The property belongs to Zayd.” Another qualifies something by an endpoint, expressed by “until” or “up to.” It seems that everyone has accepted this kind. Examples are His exalted sayings, “Do not approach them until they become pure,” “until she marries a husband other than him,” and His exalted saying, “Complete the fast until nightfall.”

It is virtually known that night differs from day in that fasting does not extend to it; likewise the menstruating woman’s condition after purification differs from her condition beforehand, as does that of the divorced woman after marrying a husband. Within this manner of speaking and all its kinds, some cases must be recognised as resembling the unambiguous (نَصّ) and possessing its force: those in which the ruling (حُكْم) is known to depend on the qualification (شَرْط) or condition. Others resemble the prima facie (ظَاهِر) or the indeterminate (مُجْمَل). In the discussion of qiyās (قِيَاس) we shall indicate the ranks of contextual indications that establish these degrees of signification (دَلَالَة).

196 Here ends the discussion of assertions and their components. Let us now examine commands and prohibitions.

5. On commands and prohibitions

197 We must also examine whether these admit the preceding division: whether unambiguous (نَصّ), prima facie (ظَاهِر), and indeterminate (مُجْمَل) cases

occur among them; and, if so, whether this is through their forms or through their understood meaning.

Meaningful speech (كَلَام), as has been said, divides into assertion, command, request, address, and supplication. Plainly, Arabic does not possess a distinct form (صِيغَة) for each of command, request, and supplication: they are distinguished by circumstantial indications. Addressed by a superior to a subordinate, it is a command; by a subordinate to a superior, a supplication; and by an equal to an equal, a request. Each of these three has an opposite. The opposite of command is prohibition (نَهْي), but the opposites of request (طَلِبَة) and supplication have no names.

198 Our purpose here is to discuss command and prohibition (نَهْي) among these divisions. A legal demand (اقتضاء) cannot be conceived as taking the form of a request—unless "request" is taken here as a generic term divided into obligation (وَاجِب) and recommendation (نَدْب). It is preferable, however, that "command" should admit this division.

They have disagreed whether the meanings of commands [subsisting] in the soul have particular forms that signify them intrinsically and primarily. If they have forms, do these unambiguously require obligation or recommendation (نَدْب)? Or is one of the two more apparent, with the form (صِيغَة) directed to the other by interpretation (تَأْوِيل), in the manner of interpreting a prima facie (ظَاهِر) expression? Or are the forms indeterminate between obligation and recommendation?

Those who hold that commands possess signifying forms also disagree whether those forms require immediate performance (فِعْل), allow delay, or remain undecided between these. Likewise, they disagree whether the forms require repetition or performance once.

199 We begin this inquiry (نَظَر) by considering how these forms stand in linguistic convention (عُرْف) and in legal usage. We say:

200 No one denies that Arabic has forms expressing a demand, such as "Go out! Depart!" These forms can nevertheless occur with the intention of threatening and deterring an action (فِعْل), as in His exalted saying, "Eat and enjoy yourselves a little." Generally, however, permission (إِذْن) is their more apparent import; they signify threat only metaphorically. Likewise, when speakers intend prohibition (نَهْي), they combine the particle lā with these forms, and the resulting combination signifies prohibition through its structure and form (صِيغَة).

Whether these forms signify command intrinsically by linguistic convention is not evident from them; still less is it evident that there are forms signifying obligation or recommendation (نَدْب) as such. These are legal meanings, not meanings of ordinary usage. By legal usage (عُرْف), however, the forms (صِيغَة) undoubtedly contain the meaning (مَعْنَى) of command. Whether they contain obligation or recommendation is disputed. Most jurists hold that commands prima facie signify obligation in the Law (شَرْع), and are directed to recommendation by evidence (دَلِيل). Some suspend judgement and regard them as indeterminate.

This should be investigated inductively in the Law, examining how the Companions, may God be pleased with them, received commands when they appeared without contextual indications. Construing them as obligatory seems more prudent, since the circumstances of the Law (شَرْع) show that its commands have a firm and decisive character. There is no sense (مَعْنَى) in assigning them what someone claims is the least that a command signifies—recommendation (نَدْب)—on the alleged ground that this always accompanies command.

201 Obligation and recommendation are two distinct meanings. Either the expression (لَفْظ) is equivocal between them or one is its more apparent meaning. If no established legal convention can be shown for these forms (صِيغَة), commands remain indeterminate between recommendation (نَدْب) and obligation until evidence (دَلِيل) indicates one of them.

As for whether their forms signify immediacy or delay, this is not contained in them: the determination depends upon circumstantial indications. Hence, when the person commanded is uncertain, it is appropriate to ask "When?" Nor is repetition of the act required merely by the imperative. It requires at least one performance (فِعْل), and is as it were prima facie in that sense, and it is construed ⟨as repeated⟩ only when a further indication is subsequently supplied.

[202] Several questions attach to this discussion; we shall set them out in their customary manner.

[203] Question. When a command to do something follows a prohibition, some hold that this circumstance redirects the demand which, standing alone, would signify either obligation or recommendation (نَدْب), so that it now signifies permission (إِبَاحَة). Others hold that this is not a contextual indication (قَرِينَة): the form (صِيغَة) of demand retains its original understood meaning.

Abū Ḥāmid says: The preferred view is that, when the prohibition (نَهْي) arises for a particular ground (عِلَّة) and the imperative "Do!" is made conditional upon its cessation—as in His exalted saying, "When you leave the state of consecration, hunt"—customary usage (عُرْف) indicates the removal of restriction (حَرَج). It may admit recommendation or [obligation], but the meaning just mentioned is more apparent.

[204] Question. The jurists' position is that an obligation to make up a missed observance (قضاء) does not require a renewed command. Those who carefully distinguish the issues hold that a command to worship (عِبَادَة) at a specified time does not require making it up. Specifying a time for worship—prayer at midday or fasting in Ramadan—is like specifying (تَخْصِيص) a place for pilgrimage or a direction for prayer. If the commanded condition (شَرْط) is absent, the command ceases to apply, when it was on account of that condition that the command concerning the act was issued.

[205] Question. The jurists hold that a command entails the sufficiency of the commanded act (إجزاء) when it is fulfilled, without an obligation to make it up. Others say that a command does not entail sufficiency: someone who has invalidated his pilgrimage is commanded to complete it, yet this does not suffice, and he must perform it again.

The correct formulation is that a command entails the sufficiency (إِجْزَاء) of the commanded act when it is performed completely, with its prescribed character and all its conditions. If a defect affects it, as with an invalidated pilgrimage, the command does not indicate sufficiency. This completes the discussion of command forms (صِيغَة).

[206] Know that the discussion of prohibitive forms parallels that of commands, and its questions correspond to theirs. Whoever construes a command form as imposing obligation construes a prohibitive form (صِيغَة) as imposing interdiction, and prohibition (نَهْي) as indicating the invalidity (فَسَاد) of the prohibited act. Whether the prohibition concerns the act without qualification or with a description or condition, it renders the underlying act invalid insofar as it bears that qualification (شَرْط) or condition.

[207] This is the question mentioned earlier in Part One, where we said that the present place would be more appropriate for discussing it.

[208] Anyone who considers a command form (صِيغَة) undecided between obligation and recommendation (نَدْب) must likewise consider a prohibitive (نَهْي) expression (لَفْظ) undecided between interdiction and disapproval (كَرَاهَة). This holds whether it concerns the underlying act without qualification or with a description or a cause (سَبَب) external to it.

Some who hold that commands and prohibitions have forms requiring obligation and interdiction nevertheless treat their application to an act qualified (مُقَيَّد) by an external cause (سَبَب) as a contextual indication (قَرِينَة). On this account the forms (صِيغَة) cease to convey obligation and interdiction and instead convey recommendation (نَدْب) and disapproval. This completes the discussion of evidence (دَلِيل) received through expressions.

[209] It remains for us to discuss signifying contextual indications, such as the Prophet's silence and tacit approval, God bless him and grant him peace. Before that, however, we must examine the evidence (دَلِيل) they call qiyās (قِيَاس).

6. On qiyās: analogy and syllogistic inference

[210] We must examine whether qiyās is legal evidence (دَلِيل) and, if it is, whether it belongs to the kinds already discussed. Our approach will be to investigate what the term qiyās (قِيَاس) signifies for them in this discipline (صِنَاعَة). We say:

They describe it as assimilating one of two things to the other in affirming or denying a ruling, when the affirmation or denial is more apparent in one than in the other, because they share a ground or attribute. They call the thing in which the ruling (حُكْم) is more apparent the original case (أصل); the thing assigned the ruling because it holds in the

original case, the derivative case (فرع); and the shared attribute or cause (سَبَب), the operative ground (علة).

[211] One should not object to our saying "two things" rather than, as in their description, "two objects of knowledge," on the alleged ground that "thing" does not apply to the nonexistent: the nonexistent is scarcely ever made a basis of comparison. Even granting their point, nothing prevents calling the nonexistent a thing insofar as it exists in the soul. Some things are in the soul as they are outside it; others are in the soul without existing outside it. In general, the theologians should not have quibbled with the Muʿtazila over this.

Nor should one attend to their saying, "because of a common factor, whether an attribute or a cause (سَبَب), or the negation of these in both." Negation as negation does not require one ruling for two things—except where negation has the force of privation, and privation follows an attribute that requires a ruling for both things. Our discussion has carried us away from our initial purpose. Let us return to where we were and say:

[212] Examining what they mean by qiyās here shows that it is not a syllogism, but belongs to using a particular (جُزْئِيّ) expression in place of the intended universal (كُلِّيّ). The evidence (دَلِيل) is that the original case (أَصْل) receives its ruling (حُكْم) through a text (نَصّ) or consensus (إِجْمَاع). If the operative ground (عِلَّة) requiring the ruling is expressly stated and is more general than the original case, this belongs to general expression (عَامّ). An example is his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, concerning water left by a cat: "[The cat] is not impure, because it is among those that circulate around you, male or female." This too has degrees; many who reject qiyās (قِيَاس) allow such cases.

If the ground (عِلَّة) requiring the ruling (حُكْم) is not expressly stated, but the expression's understood meaning (مَفْهُوم) requires it and it is more general than the original case (أَصْل), this is using a particular (جُزْئِيّ) expression (لَفْظ) in place of the intended universal. We then assign the ruling to anything shown, through independent inquiry or sense perception (حِسّ), to fall under that universal (كُلِّيّ). An example is his prohibition of drinking from silver vessels, God bless him and grant him peace. Extravagance is understood from it; hence we extend the ruling to gold vessels.

[213] Since this is so, what they mean by qiyās (قِيَاس) in this discipline (صِنَاعَة) generally comes back to what expressions require through their understood meanings. Expressions require this only through accompanying contextual indications —not just any indications, but those whose kind the Law (شَرْع) demonstrably takes into account. The situation is thus like that of ordinary communication.

Just as the contextual indications on which a Bedouin relies when addressing another must be known to the addressee, and the speaker's attention to them in speaking must be known, so it must be in the Law (شَرْع). We shall indicate them individually and arrange them according to the rank of each in clarity.

[214] As we said, contextual indications can make a statement unambiguous (نَصّ) through its understood meaning, when they establish its metaphor or substitution decisively; or prima facie (ظَاهِر) through its understood meaning, when they are preponderant rather than decisive; or indeterminate (مُجْمَل), when they remain undecided. We should therefore indicate their ranks here, although they are difficult to delimit precisely. We say:

[215] The first rank has the status of an unambiguous (نَصّ) expression: the ruling (حُكْم) applies with greater reason to the unmentioned case than to the stated one. Examples are His exalted saying, "God does not wrong anyone by an atom's weight," and His saying, mighty and exalted, "Do not say 'Uff' to the two of them"; likewise the Prophet's saying, peace be upon him, "Hand over the thread and the needle," and similar expressions. This has a range of clarity. They call it the purport of the discourse (فحوى الخطاب), and most do not call it qiyās (قِيَاس).

[216] The second rank is where the unmentioned case has the same relevant meaning as the stated case with respect to the ruling (حُكْم). An example is his saying, peace be upon him, "Whoever emancipates his share in a slave must have the remainder assessed against him." The case of a female slave is included with that of a male slave, since it has the same relevant meaning. They call this analogy within the meaning of the original

case (الأصل معنى في القياس). This too has a range of greater and lesser clarity.

217 The third rank is of the same kind (جِنْس) as the second: it is prima facie. In most cases, however, its clarity is weaker, so we have placed it third. Here the unmentioned case is joined to the stated one because of a shared benefit (مصلحة), whose kind the Law (شَرْع) has acknowledged as beneficial. They call this analogy from a plausible, suitable ground (القياس المخيل والمناسب).

This kind (جِنْس) has degrees of proximity and remoteness. When it is very close, they call it a congruent suitable ground (المناسب الملائم); many proponents of qiyās stop here. When it is intermediate, they do not call it congruent, but suitable and plausible (مُخَيِّل). When it is very remote and completely general, as when we simply say "benefit (مَصْلَحَة)," many proponents of qiyās (قِيَاس) reject it. Some jurists reason in this way when holding that divorce pronounced by a sick man does not cut off inheritance.

This last kind (جِنْس) rightly deserves rejection as legal evidence, since benefits often diverge and vary with each time and circumstance. Those who reason this way are in fact legislating, rather than deriving rulings from the Law (شَرْع). An example is someone's saying, "New rulings arise for people in proportion to the new wickedness they introduce," or words to that effect. Mālik, God have mercy upon him, has been reproached for this, because he often attends to this kind.

218 The fourth rank is what they call analogy by resemblance (الشبه قياس). The unmentioned case is joined to the stated one neither because it has a stronger claim, nor because it shares the same relevant meaning, nor because of a suitable operative ground (عِلَّة). Rather, a resemblance between them suggests that it contains a ground common to both cases and appropriate to the ruling (حُكْم), although that ground has not been identified.

Most cases of this kind (جِنْس) seem indeterminate, unless they join the second rank, which is within the meaning of the original case (أَصْل). An example is his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, "Do not sell wheat for wheat—the four known commodities—except hand to hand." Some say he intended staple nourishment, some food, and some goods measured by volume. All this is their probable judgement (ظَنّ): nourishment, measure, or edibility circumscribes the suitable (مُنَاسِب) factor requiring prohibition. To me this seems the remotest contextual indication (قَرِينَة) used to understand a universal (كُلِّيّ) meaning (مَعْنَى) from a particular (جُزْئِيّ) expression (لَفْظ). Many therefore confine such a report to what its wording requires.

219 Know that the classes of prescribed matters differ in how clearly these contextual indications appear within them. Hence Abū Ḥanīfa did not permit qiyās (قِيَاس) in fixed penalties and expiations. It is clearer in matters of necessity, such as sale, marriage, and the like. As we said before, when an expression (لَفْظ) first appears it may be unknown whether it is a specific expression (خَاصّ) substituted for a general (عَامّ) one. In some cases that is known, but the universal (كُلِّيّ) for which it has been substituted is unknown.

220 Here proponents of qiyās (قِيَاس) employ the kind of inference called testing and division (السبر والتقسيم). Some, though fewer, also employ positive and negative concomitance (الطرد والعكس). We must explain how they use these.

221 When it is unknown whether a particular (جُزْئِيّ) expression has been used to express a universal (كُلِّيّ) meaning, testing and division (سَبْر وَتَقْسِيم) proceeds as follows. We say: either this particular expression (لَفْظ) is used to express a universal meaning or it retains its original meaning. We then show that it does not retain that meaning (مَعْنَى). Next we must determine which universal is intended. We enumerate all the universal meanings probably intended by the particular expression, eliminate them one by one until only one remains, and judge that this is the universal intended by that particular.

If it is apparent from the outset that a particular (جُزْئِيّ) expression (لَفْظ) has been substituted for a universal (كُلِّيّ), but not apparent which universal, we employ testing and division (سَبْر وَتَقْسِيم) to determine it.

222 Positive concomitance (طرد) occurs when a ruling (حُكْم) is given concerning something and we assign it to another thing because of a resemblance we find between them, applying it uniformly to the latter. On this basis we judge that the expression

(لَفْظ) has been cast in particular (جُزْئِيّ) form while intending the universal (كُلِّيّ) in which the two resemble one another.

This procedure may be strengthened by considering both presence and absence: any universal (كُلِّيّ) whose presence brings the ruling and whose absence removes it is taken as the ground on which the ruling depends (الحكم مناط). This is what they call negative concomitance (عكس). Most proponents of qiyās (قِيَاس) agree in rejecting the determination of a ruling's ground through positive and negative concomitance.

[223] In general, it appears that in most cases proponents of qiyās in the Law (شَرْع) do not use it to derive an unknown ruling (حُكْم) from a known one, in the way an unknown conclusion is derived from intellectually apprehended premises. They use it to establish the correctness of substituting (إِبْدَال) expressions in each context (قَرِينَة) and case. What they call analogy from a plausible (مُخَيِّل), suitable (مُنَاسِب) ground and analogy by resemblance are contextual indications of verbal substitution. They are not syllogisms and perform no syllogistic (قِيَاس) operation, although those studying this discipline (صِنَاعَة) have not clearly recognised the distinction.

This is evident from their arguments against those who reject qiyās, whom they call the Ẓāhirīs (أهل الظاهر, "People of the Apparent"). The latter confronted them with a difficulty they could not escape: where knowledge comes through revelation and God's command, intellects have no part in affirming or denying anything of it. Moreover, rulings are not attributes of things' essences that intellects can apprehend. In general, qiyās (قِيَاس) has no part in whatever depends upon authoritative instruction (توقيف); its means of knowledge is transmitted communication (سمع), as with languages and similar things.

This objection applies only to someone who reasons from an original case (أَصْل) whose wording (لَفْظ) contains no indication (تَنْبِيه) pointing to the underlying ground (عِلَّة)—for example, analogising the penalty for wine drinking to that for an unsubstantiated accusation of illicit intercourse (قذف). It does not apply to someone whose original case includes its operative ground in the understood meaning (مَعْنَى), even if the verbal form (صِيغَة) does not contain it. Most legal instances of qiyās (قِيَاس) belong to this kind. Had they understood this point, they could have answered their opponents.

[224] The Ẓāhirīs, and anyone allowing inference (اسْتِدْلَال) from expressions' prima facie forms, should therefore not deny analogy within the original case (أَصْل)'s meaning (مَعْنَى), or analogy (قِيَاس) from a plausible (مُخَيِّل) and congruently suitable (مُنَاسِب) ground, when the Law (شَرْع) demonstrably attends to its proximate kind. These are all contextual indications that make expressions prima facie through their understood meanings, even when they are not so through their forms. There is no sense in recognising prima facie (ظَاهِر) signification only in verbal form (صِيغَة).

[225] Proponents of qiyās have sought to establish it through the Companions' consensus. They transmitted statements from many Companions which, they claimed, support qiyās. The Ẓāhirīs challenged them on two grounds. First, consensus (إِجْمَاع) itself was unestablished: such statements were not transmitted from all the Companions, and, as explained earlier, a speaker's statement cannot be attributed to someone silent. Second, had consensus occurred, disagreement would not have been transmitted from the Successors. They also cited reports from the Companions rejecting qiyās (قِيَاس). In general, its proponents could not establish their claimed consensus.

Moreover, the Companions' transmitted expressions about qiyās admit several interpretations. On examination they seem likely to disclose the meaning (مَعْنَى) we have assigned to qiyās (قِيَاس): the Companions were exercising independent inquiry into expressions' understood meanings. What the Ẓāhirīs seem entitled to resist is deriving substitution (إِبْدَال) or metaphor (اسْتِعَارَة) through testing and division (سَبْر وَتَقْسِيم), or through other procedures, when none of the contextual indications we have enumerated is present.

Anyone who permits that procedure should permit it for all expressions involving substitution, metaphor, omission, or, generally, alteration. Just as these contextual indications can generalise a specific expression (خَاصّ), they can also restrict a general (عَامّ) one.

[226] This discussion has shown what the term qiyās (قِيَاس) signifies in this discipline (صِنَاعَة), which class (جِنْس) of legal evidence (دَلِيل) it belongs to, and where it may and may not be used. Among the ways of legal evidence, there remain the Prophet's action and tacit approval, God bless him and grant him peace. These are evidence through their character as contextual indications, rather than through verbal forms (صِيغَة) or understood meanings. We shall discuss each of them and its force.

7. On tacit approval

[227] As for his tacit approval, God bless him and grant him peace: when an act (فِعْل) is done in his presence and it is certainly known that he saw and approved it, this shows that the act may occur in that manner and—if it is a legal judgement—that it is binding. Or it shows permissibility (إِبَاحَة) when the act had been supposed forbidden. This follows from his established protection from error in what he called people to and in what he approved, God bless him and grant him peace.

8. On action

[228] His actions, God bless him and grant him peace, are of several kinds. One explains a general or indeterminate (مُجْمَل) expression. Such an action (فِعْل) by him, God bless him and grant him peace, bears the ruling (حُكْم) of the general expression (عَامّ): if that is recommended, the action is recommended (مَنْدُوب); if obligatory, the action is obligatory (وَاجِب). The evidence (دَلِيل) is his saying, peace be upon him, "Pray as you have seen me pray, and take your pilgrimage rites from me."

[229] The second kind is the opposite: it is known through a circumstantial or verbal indicator ⟨that the action (فِعْل) is peculiar to him. The third is⟩ intermediate between these two: actions of his, God bless him and grant him peace, for which it is unknown whether they explain an indeterminate (مُجْمَل) expression (لَفْظ), clarify a general (عَامّ) one, or are peculiar to him. Here people disagree. Some construe them as obligatory, others as recommended (نَدْب), and others withhold judgement. This is Abū Ḥāmid's preferred view, because an action has no verbal form (صِيغَة).

Those construing the action (فِعْل) as obligatory cite prima facie expressions that nevertheless admit other meanings, such as His exalted saying, "In God's Messenger you have a good example." Those construing it as recommended (نَدْب) appeal to the Companions' imitation of his actions, God bless him and grant him peace: removing their sandals in prayer when he removed his, and refraining from shaving in the year of al-Ḥudaybiyya until he shaved. Proponents of obligation can also appeal to these actions of the Companions, may God be pleased with them.

In reply, someone who holds that an action (فِعْل) establishes no ruling may say: the Companions acted this way only where they knew, from either circumstantial indications or a statement, that he, God bless him and grant him peace, was explaining obligations or recommendations through his action. In general, the question admits independent judgement (حُكْم). The more apparent view is that no ruling can be assigned on the basis of this kind of action by him, God bless him and grant him peace, since it remains undecided between obligation, recommendation (نَدْب), permission (إِبَاحَة), and being peculiar to him.

When his actions, peace be upon him, explain [an indeterminate expression] or clarify a general (عَامّ) one and conflict, they have the same status as two conflicting statements. We shall discuss this later, as also the conflict (تَعَارُض) of an action (فِعْل) with a statement. Here ends the discussion in Part Three of this book.

Part IV · Ijtihād

Part Four

[230] It comprises three chapters: one on independent juristic inquiry (اِجْتِهَاد), one on following authority (تَقْلِيد), and one on weighing (تَرْجِيح) the evidence (دَلِيل).

Chapter One. On independent juristic inquiry

[231] Its discussion divides into examination of the independent jurist (مجتهد), the subject of his inquiry, and independent inquiry itself (اجتهاد). Independent inquiry (نَظَر) is the jurist's exertion of his utmost capacity in seeking an answer by means of the instruments required of him.

The definition (حَدّ) of the independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) is that he knows the sources (أَصْل) from which he derives rulings and possesses the rules and requisite conditions by which he derives them. Since the sources are three—the Book, the Sunna

(سُنَّة), and consensus (إِجْمَاع)—we must state how much knowledge of each suffices for him.

232 Sufficient knowledge (عِلْم) of the Book consists in knowing the verses containing rulings and distinguishing the abrogating from the abrogated among them; they number about five hundred verses. This is a concession (رُخْصَة): knowing the whole Book is preferable. He is also excused from memorising the verses containing rulings if he knows where they occur, so that when a question arises he knows where to look for them.

233 Sufficient knowledge of the Sunna (سُنَّة) consists in knowing the reports that contain rulings. He may be excused from memorising them: it is enough to possess a corrected collection of all the reports containing rulings, to which he can refer when a legal opinion is needed. Memorizing them is preferable.

As for knowing the soundness (صَحِيح) of their transmission chains, if he relies on someone he trusts, such as al-Bukhārī or Muslim, he is following authority. Yet if he must himself establish the transmitters' uprightness and investigate their biographies, circumstances, and dates, the task becomes protracted and immensely intricate, especially as time grows distant. The concession is to accept a leading scholar's accreditation (تَعْدِيل), provided he knows that scholar's approach to discrediting and accrediting transmitters and it agrees with his own.

234 As for consensus, he should know all the questions on which consensus (إِجْمَاع) has been reached. It may suffice that he knows his opinion on the question he is answering does not oppose consensus, by knowing that it agrees with an opinion someone has held. Before all this, he must possess enough knowledge (عِلْم) of vocabulary and language to understand the Book of God, exalted is He, and the Sunna (سُنَّة) of His Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, without linguistic error.

235 They also require knowledge of theology (علم الكلام): possession of the evidence (دَلِيل) giving knowledge of God and His attributes, leading to knowledge of the world's origination, and the other matters theology contains. This is required only on the view that the first obligation is rational examination and inference (اسْتِدْلَال). On the other view, faith based simply on the Law (شَرْع) suffices without rational examination (نَظَر). As for the derived details of jurisprudence (فِقْه), he has no need of them, because it is the independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) who generates them.

236 These requirements as a whole apply to the independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) in the unrestricted sense, who can give a legal opinion in every case. Someone who possesses only some of them may exercise independent inquiry in a question for which the requirements he possesses are sufficient. His relation to that question is the same as that of the unrestricted independent jurist to all questions.

237 The subject of independent inquiry is every legal ruling for which there is no decisive evidence (دَلِيل). We must consider whether the ruling (حُكْم) sought is determinate in itself and one is charged with attaining it, or whether no determinate ruling exists toward which the inquiry is directed, the obligation resting solely on attaining a preponderant judgement. On the latter account, every independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) would be correct, even when their opinions on the same thing contradict one another. We say:

238 Whoever holds that rulings are attributes of things' essences—whether known when the Law is added, or beforehand, or with both kinds among them, as the Muʿtazila hold—cannot declare every independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) correct. The same applies to those rejecting qiyās (قِيَاس) in the Law (شَرْع). They too hold that whatever has received no legal discourse (خِطَاب) remains under original freedom from obligation, as permissible; whereas something receiving legal discourse has a determinate ruling (حُكْم).

239 Our own position has already been stated: legal rulings are apprehended through discourse (خِطَاب), which sometimes requires a ruling (حُكْم) through its form and sometimes through its understood meaning. What they mean by qiyās (قِيَاس) falls within this class (جِنْس). Both kinds divide, with respect to the obligation to act on them, into unambiguous (نَصّ) and prima facie (ظَاهِر) indications. Consequently, one cannot maintain that every independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) is correct, since rulings are received through the given discourse in all the kinds we have enumerated, whether verbal expression (لَفْظ) or contextual indication (قَرِينَة).

Where knowledge comes through discourse, there is undoubtedly a determinate ruling (حُكْم): that to which the discourse relates. What the given discourse (خِطَاب) does not contain, and no contextual indication (قَرِينَة) signifies, remains under original freedom from obligation and is excused. This is one kind of permission (مُبَاح) ascribed to the Law (شَرْع). This is the meaning (مَعْنَى) of His saying, mighty and exalted, "We have neglected nothing in the Book": nothing bearing a ruling is left uncontained there; whatever it does not contain through any of the forms of legal evidence (دَلِيل) is passed over.

[240] Abū Ḥāmid holds here that every independent jurist is correct. He has enumerated and rejected the objections to that claim, but has not included the argument we have given. He follows two routes in establishing that every independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) is correct. We shall show that his alleged consequences do not follow.

His first route is this. He says: if there were a determinate ruling (حُكْم) in matters whose path is independent inquiry, the obligation would concern attaining it. In that case there would be decisive evidence (دَلِيل) leading to it; otherwise this would impose an obligation beyond one's capacity, which has already been shown impossible.

He then attempts to show that the indications used in independent inquiry are probable, yield the two contradictories equally, and acquire preponderance only according to each person's natural inclination in each ruling (حُكْم) and each case.

[241] To say such a thing is a grave offence and a resort to arbitrary judgement in the Law (شَرْع) through desires and inclinations; we seek God's protection from it. Legal evidence (دَلِيل), as we said, is either decisive or preponderantly probable, with action on the latter required by a certainly established principle (أَصْل). In either case the ruling (حُكْم) undoubtedly follows from the evidence itself, according to its signification, not according to each person's natural disposition.

Hence an indication (دَلِيل) undecided equally between contradictories is called indeterminate in this discipline (صِنَاعَة) and is not accepted as legal evidence at all. In general, denying that evidence itself yields what is sought—whether the evidence is rational or legal—is a thoroughly sophistical claim, to be avoided because of its great harm to the Law. Since evidence leading to the object sought exists, requiring one to attain it is not an obligation beyond one's capacity.

[242] His other argument is drawn from obligation. Since the obligatory was defined as that whose omission incurs punishment, he argues: if the obligation (وَاجِب) concerning a thing were a determinate ruling, failure to attain it would incur sin. But consensus (إِجْمَاع) establishes that independent jurists are not charged with sin. Therefore, the absence of sin entails the absence of error (خَطَأ).

[243] We say that exemption from sin does not entail absence of error. Unintentional error (خَطَأ) is pardoned in the Law (شَرْع); it occurs through forgetfulness, inattention, and inadvertence. We have repeatedly said that legal evidence (دَلِيل) is either decisive or preponderant. The path to decisive evidence is plainly accessible, and inadvertence and mistake are rare in it; hence error there seems to entail sin. With probable evidence, however, mistake and inadvertence occur often, so error does not entail sin.

The definition (حَدّ) of the obligatory as that whose omission incurs punishment means that punishment attaches to omission after its obligatory status has become known, where decisive evidence (دَلِيل) leads to that knowledge. If someone errs or is inadvertent in a matter liable to error (خَطَأ) and thus has no way to know its obligatory (وَاجِب) status, how could he incur sin? The Prophet, peace be upon him, has said, "Error and forgetfulness have been lifted from my community."

[244] If it is said that this entails freedom from sin even when a jurist (مُجْتَهِد) unintentionally misses something established by decisive evidence (دَلِيل), we reply: this requires examination. The difference is clear. Decisive evidence is seldom hidden from someone who has attained the rank of independent inquiry (نَظَر). Its being hidden is conceivable only through desire, partiality, something opposing it, or other psychological impediments. This has degrees corresponding to the degrees of evidence. Hence some cases incur a judgement of unbelief and others a charge of sin; the Law (شَرْع) determines these differences.

245 Our discussion has shown that not every independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) is correct, in what respect he is free from sin when he errs, and that he is charged with attaining something that is itself attainable. When he errs, he is forgiven out of mercy and pardon.

246 It remains to consider the jurist's position when evidence (دَلِيل) conflicts for him on a question, and what course he should take. Abū Ḥāmid reports three views: suspending judgement, adopting the more cautious course, and the Judge's view that the jurist (مُجْتَهِد) may choose. This last view is weak, because granting a choice is permission (إِبَاحَة), whereas contradictory evidence concerning the command about a single matter is more apt to produce doubt and perplexity than to be thought to establish such permission.

Suspending judgement (حُكْم) likewise makes no sense (مَعْنَى), since it leaves rulings inoperative. It is also impossible where a person must do one of two opposite things. Consider the reports about ritual bathing because of the emission of fluid, and bathing because of the meeting of the circumcised parts. When such reports conflict, suspension (تَوَقُّف) is impossible: one must adopt one or the other.

In such a case, adopting the more cautious course appears plausible. Although it may seem preferable because it avoids blame, one must equally fear blame for adding to the Law (شَرْع) something that does not belong to it.

247 The Ẓāhirīs have a fourth view: when the evidence (دَلِيل) is equally balanced, the independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) returns to original freedom from obligation. An obligation imposed through contradictory evidence exceeds one's capacity and is like an obligation lacking evidence. Just as original freedom from obligation is presumed to continue where there is no evidence —or where evidence exists but cannot be reached —it likewise continues where available proofs appear to conflict. And just as a ruling supported by evidence does not bind someone whom that evidence has not reached, so apparently opposed proofs cease to bind the person for whom they conflict.

These two conditions occur only relative to particular people or people of a particular period: those whom the legal evidence (دَلِيل) has not reached, or who have not distinguished the abrogating from the abrogated, or other matters producing conflict (تَعَارُض). For contradictory evidence cannot occur within the Law (شَرْع) itself.

248 Having completed the discussion of independent inquiry and its subject matter, let us discuss following authority (تَقْلِيد) and the person who does so.

Chapter Two. On following authority

249 Following authority (تقليد) is accepting someone's statement whose truth is judged preponderantly probable (ظَنّ) because of confidence in that person. It differs from following the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace: following him is accepting a statement of which one attains certainty (يَقِين), because the miracle indicates his truthfulness, God bless him and grant him peace.

250 Those permitted to follow authority are ordinary people. The proof (دَلِيل) is that people must fall under one of three arrangements. Either all are independent jurists; this is impossible both in practice and as an obligation, since, even if everyone could attain that rank, it would bring the means of livelihood to a halt.

Or all lack the qualifications for independent inquiry. This too is impossible, because it would lead to the neglect of most rulings: independent jurists are those who discharge the obligation (فَرْض) of knowing most prescribed duties and practices and teaching them to people.

Or both classes exist: one group preserves the prescribed duties and practices for the public, lays them upon people, requires their observance, and derives what may be derived from them at each time and in each case. Another group, ordinary people, follows the authority of the first because of confidence in them and a preponderant judgement of their truthfulness.

Here it is as though preponderant judgement based on confidence has been made a sign that the rulings bind them, just as the independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد)'s preponderant judgement (حُكْم) is a sign that a ruling binds him. This is rightly called a collective obligation (وَاجِب) (فرض كفاية), since its performance by some suffices on behalf of others.

251 It is therefore clear that people are of two classes. One is obliged to follow authority:

ordinary people who have not attained the rank of independent inquiry defined earlier. The second comprises independent jurists who fully possess its qualifications.

Whether those in the second class may follow one another's authority requires examination. Ordinary people's following authority (تَقْلِيد) is required by necessity (ضَرُورَة) and established by consensus (إِجْمَاع). Nevertheless, one should say that an independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) may follow another who is more knowledgeable than he, when his confidence in the other's judgement outweighs the probable judgement (ظَنّ) he himself reaches through independent inquiry (نَظَر) into the matter.

Section

[252] There is a group resembling ordinary people in one respect and independent jurists in another: those mostly called jurists in our time. We should examine to which class they more properly belong. Their condition plainly shows that their rank is that of ordinary people and that they are followers of authority.

They differ from ordinary people by memorising independent jurists' opinions and reporting them to others, without themselves possessing the qualifications for independent inquiry. Their rank is thus like that of transmitters from independent jurists. Had they stopped there, matters would have been more fitting. Instead, they go beyond it, analogising cases for which no ruling (حُكْم) has been transmitted (نَقْل) from their authorities to cases for which one has. They make a source (أَصْل) of what is not a source, turning independent jurists' statements into sources for their own inquiry. That is sufficient error and innovation!

[253] May they, however, remain in the first condition: transmitting from an independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد) whom they judge probably correct, with successors carefully transmitting from predecessors, so that, for example (مِثَال), no one in our time discharges the obligation (فَرْض) of independent inquiry, apart from those of the past? Would it suffice that someone in the earliest period discharged it, even one man or more, as we find among these groups—the Mālikīs, Shāfiʿīs, and Ḥanafīs?

By my life, consensus (إِجْمَاع) proves that this is impermissible: for every collective obligation there must be someone in every period who performs it; only then does it cease to bind the others. Moreover, the cases that arise are without limit. It is impossible to transmit from earlier independent jurists a separate pronouncement for every case.

[254] This leaves only three possibilities: to make earlier independent jurists' legal opinions into sources from which rulings are derived; to leave many rulings inoperative; or, since both alternatives are impermissible, to accept the third —that no period should be without an independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد).

You know that the period just past was in this condition: it had no practising independent jurist (مُجْتَهِد). Although it cannot be denied that someone in it had attained the rank of independent inquiry, he nevertheless acted only as a follower of authority.

[255] This discussion has clarified who follows authority, what following authority (تَقْلِيد) is, and where it is and is not valid.

Chapter Three. On weighing transmission routes

[256] There remains the third chapter, concerning the comparative weight of transmission (نَقْل) routes and of what expressions signify through their understood meanings. This concerns evidence (دَلِيل) of the same kind, since the relative weight of different kinds has already been established. The relevant rules attach to particular items of evidence and particular chains of transmission, and are virtually without limit.

Practitioners of this discipline (صِنَاعَة) have attempted to enumerate them. We have no need to do so, since a person can determine for himself which produce a preponderant judgement and which do not. Anyone with leisure who wishes to record them here may do so. However, the contextual indications establishing the superiority of transmission (نَقْل) routes should be placed in the discussion of reports (خَبَر), and those establishing the superiority of an understood meaning (مَفْهُوم) in Part Three of this book.

[257] That adopting and acting upon the stronger of two probable judgements constitutes legal evidence (دَلِيل) is shown by the Companions' consensus (إِجْمَاع) on this, and by what a person

finds in himself: he turns to the stronger of two probable judgements when they conflict.

[258] Here our purpose in this abridgement is complete. It resembles an abridgement in removing prolixity, and an original work in its additions and completions. This was during the middle ten days of Dhū al-Ḥijja in the year five hundred and fifty-two.

The later copyist's record and scholarly apparatus remain in the reference edition.